

FOR THE EYES OF THE KEEPER ALONE

BLOOD & GRIT

A ROLEPLAYING GAME OF THE HAUNTED
FRONTIER

THE KEEPER'S BOOK

Compiled in the Territories · Edition of 1885 · Version 2.9

Companion to the Player's Book · the secrets, the monsters, and the running of the dark





"Someone at every fire must keep the watch while the rest dream of grass and gold. I have kept it so long I have forgotten how to look at a sunset and see only the sun."

— ATTRIBUTED TO A KEEPER OF THE OLD TALES, THE NAME WORN FROM THE PAGE



"The trick was never the frightening — any fool with a candle can frighten. The trick is the fairness: letting them see, the breath before the dark takes them, the one turn they should not have taken."

— FROM THE MARGINS OF A KEEPER'S LEDGER



Contents

The order of the dark, and where to find it.

This is the Keeper's Book. It holds what the Player's Book withholds — the reckoning behind the rules of fear, the things that wait in the dark, and the craft of setting them loose without breaking faith with the souls at your table. If you mean to play and not to run, close it.

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I. The Keeper's Chair

What you are for, and the bargain you make with the table.



*The players brought the heroes. You brought the country — and it was here first,
and it will be here when the last of them is a name cut in a boot-hill board.*

— N. ASHBY



*A word before the work, from one host to another. Your players sat down for a western —
give them one. Let the first night be cattle prices and bad coffee and a gun that means
exactly what a gun means. The dark in this game earns nothing by arriving early; it
earns everything by arriving eventually, through a door the players propped open
themselves on some ordinary afternoon. You are not the monster's advocate. You are the
ordinary evening the monster interrupts — and the longer that evening stays believably
ordinary, the further down it can afterward go.*

Every other soul at the table plays one person trying to last another day. You play everything else — the town and the trail, the weather and the wolves, the kindly stranger and the thing wearing his face. More than that, you play the **country itself**, which in this game is old, and patient, and not on anyone's side. The players brought characters. You bring the dark they walked into.

What This Book Is

The Player's Book makes a character and keeps them breathing — the dice, the callings, the guns, the rules of fear from the inside. This book is the other half: the DCs you set, the monsters you run, the way dread is paced so it lands, and the judgment calls the rules leave to you on purpose. Read the Player's Book first; this one assumes it. Where the two ever disagree, the Keeper's word settles it at the table and a note in the margin settles it after.

The Promise

Blood & Grit is a western that curdles. It opens in a world the players think they understand — dust, debt, a hard ride, a harder town — and somewhere in the first night the ground gives a little under their feet. Your promise to the table is twofold, and you owe both halves equally:

- **Fairness.** The dice fall where they fall. Death is on the table, but it is earned by the fiction, never sprung from spite. The players should always be able to point at the moment it went wrong and say *we should have known*.
- **Dread.** You promised them horror, not a card game with a skull on the box. If a session ends and no one's skin crawled, the machinery worked and the game didn't. Dread is the deliverable.

Tone: The Slow Burn

The single most common way a Blood & Grit session fails is the Keeper showing the monster in the first ten minutes. Resist it. The country curdles in three movements, and you should feel each one before you move to the next:

- **The Ordinary West.** Let it be a real place first. A name, a face, a debt, a job. Let the players relax into the genre — gunslingers and ghost towns — so that the floor has somewhere to drop.
- **The Wrong Note.** One detail that doesn't sit right. The dog won't go in the barn. The new grave is open and clean. The preacher's shadow falls the wrong way. Don't explain it. Let it itch.
- **The Reckoning.** The dark stops hinting. Now the guns come out, the Nerve bleeds, and the players learn what the wrong note was always pointing at.

KEEPER'S EYE

The horror is strongest in the gap between the wrong note and the reckoning. Stretch that gap. A monster seen is a problem to be shot; a monster *suspected* is a dread that follows the players home.

Session Zero

Before the First Die Is Cast

Spend a half-hour, before anyone rolls, settling these:

- **The pitch.** "A gritty western where the frontier is haunted by something older than the country, and your characters are ordinary people who will not stay ordinary." Make sure everyone wants that.
- **Lines & veils.** Name what won't go on the page (a *line*) and what happens off it (a *veil*). This is a horror game; harm to children, certain real cruelties, and anything a player names are off the table, no questions asked. The dark has range enough without them.
- **Ties.** Have each player give one reason their character is here and one person, place, or debt they'd ride into hell for. That is the rope you will pull on all campaign long.

Before the First Die Is Cast (cont.)

- **The town.** Name the starting town together. Let each player add one thing to it. A place they helped build is a place that hurts to lose.

Pacing the Table

Keep scenes moving and the spotlight turning — everyone should act before anyone acts twice. Cut hard to the next thing that matters; "you ride three days and reach the Wells" is a fine sentence. Save your slow, lingering description for the wrong note and the reckoning, where dread lives. And learn to sit in silence after something awful: do not rush to fill it. The quiet is doing your work for you.

Reading Your Table

The rules are the same for every group; the table is not. After a few sessions you will be running not one game but five or six people who each came for something a little different, and the craft of keeping is partly the craft of seeing what each of them is after and feeding it without starving the rest. A few types you will meet, and what to do with them:

- **The one who came to be scared.** They lean in at the wrong note, they want the dread. Give them the secret Notice rolls, the slow reveals, the thing glimpsed and not explained. They are your best instrument; play the horror partly to them and the rest of the table catches it.
- **The one who came to shoot.** Nothing wrong with it — this is a western. Give them the gunfight, the standoff, the moment their iron is the only answer. But teach them, gently and early, that some nights the gun makes it worse, so the lesson lands before it costs the party someone.

- **The one who came to solve.** They want the mystery, the clue, the why. Build them a real puzzle with a real answer — the cursed object's origin, the cult's weak link, the tell that names the monster — and never make the solution a die roll they can flub into a dead end.
- **The quiet one.** Not every player drives the scene, and that is fine, but make sure the spotlight finds them on their terms. Ask them directly what their character does, hand them a private clue, give them the NPC who trusts only them. A quiet player is often the most invested; they are just waiting to be invited.
- **The one pulling away from the table.** The lone wolf, the murder-hobo, the player whose character keeps wandering off alone or turning on the others. Usually this is boredom or a want unmet, not malice. Talk to them away from the table, find the want, and write it into the story — a tie, a grudge, a goal that needs the others. A character with a reason to ride with the party rarely rides away from it.

THE CHECK-IN

Once an arc or so, ask the table plainly: are you having the kind of fun you came for? Too scary, not scary enough, too much fighting, not enough? It costs five minutes and breaks no immersion that a season of quiet resentment wouldn't break worse. The best Keepers adjust; only the proud ones guess.

II. Running the Game

The loop, the numbers, and when to reach for the dice.



Roll the bones only when the answer matters and you do not already know it.

The rest is talk — and talk is where the game lives.

— MARSHAL T. COYLE



Underneath the dread, the machine is simple and you should keep it that way. You describe a situation; a player says what their character does; if the outcome is uncertain and failure is interesting, the dice settle it; you narrate what changes; you describe the new situation. Round and round until the story ends or they do. Everything else in this chapter is in service of that loop.

When to Call for a Roll

Do not roll for everything. A roll is for moments that are **both uncertain and consequential**. If success is assured, say yes. If failure is dull ("you fail to open the unlocked door"), say yes. Reach for the dice only when both a win and a loss would push the story somewhere worth going. Each roll you call should be able to answer the question: *what new trouble does failure buy?*

Setting the DC

When you do call for a roll, you set the number to beat. Hold to one ladder so the table learns its rhythm:

Difficulty	DC	What it feels like
Trivial	10	A trained hand barely thinks about it
Easy	13	Routine, but the green can still flub it
Average	15	A fair test of a capable person
Hard	18	Sweat on the brow; the day's real obstacle
Very Hard	20	Few try it; fewer manage
Punishing	25	The stuff of stories told after
Beyond	30	The country says no, but you may ask

To beat a living thing — a shot, a swing, a lie told to its face — the DC is that creature's **Defense** or the relevant save it gets to resist with, not a number off this table. Use the ladder for the world; use Defense and saves for the things in it.

The Four Degrees

Every roll has four outcomes, and you should narrate all four, never just hit-or-miss. Beat the DC by **10 or more** (or roll a natural 20 that already succeeds) for a **critical success**; miss it by **10 or more** (or roll a natural 1 that already fails) for a **critical failure**. A natural 20 bumps the result one step better, a natural 1 one step worse. Spend critical successes on grace — a free truth, a saved bullet, an enemy's nerve broken — and critical failures on the kind of trouble the players will be telling stories about. That is where the texture of the game lives.

Rolling in the Dark

Some checks the players must not see the result of, or the result tells them what they failed to learn. Roll these yourself, behind the screen: **Notice** against a hidden thing, **Lore (Occult)** to read a sign, anything where a known failure would itself be a clue. On a failure they simply learn nothing, and never know whether there was nothing to learn or they merely missed it. Doubt is a tool. Use it.

Success at a Cost

When a player just misses on something the story wants to keep moving, offer the deal instead of the dead end: *you can have it, but...* — the door opens but the noise carries; the wound is bound but the laudanum's gone; you cross the river but the powder's wet. "Failing forward" keeps the night advancing toward its reckoning instead of stalling at a locked door.

The Trail & the Long Quiet

Travel is not dead time; it is your best dread-builder. The long ride between the town and the wrong place is where you plant the wrong note — the cold that comes too early, the birds gone silent, the homesteads emptier the further out they go. Provisioning matters here (see the Player's Book, Chapter X): a party that rode out short on salt, lamp-oil, and shells is a party you can squeeze. Don't roll for every mile; roll for the mile that costs something.

The Dark Has a Plan

THE CLOCK

Give the dark a goal and a count of how long until it gets there — a clock of four to six steps. The cult needs three more nights to finish the rite; the taint spreads one homestead a week; the thing under the mine wakes by the new moon. Tick it forward whenever the players dawdle, fail, or look away. A ticking clock turns a haunted set-piece into a living threat the players are racing, and it tells you, with no agonizing, what happens when

THE CLOCK (CONT.)

they don't show up.

Running a Mystery Without Stalling It

Most Blood & Grit nights are mysteries at heart — what's killing the stock, who's wearing the wrong face, why won't the dead lie down — and the most common way a session dies is a mystery that locks. The players miss the roll, find the empty room, run out of leads, and the night grinds to a halt while everyone stares at the table. A few habits keep the dark moving toward them:

- **Never gate the core clue behind a roll.** The thing the players *must* know to proceed is not a Notice check they can fail — it is simply there to be found by anyone who looks. Roll for the bonus, the edge, the thing that makes it easier; never for the thread the whole night hangs on. The rule of three: put the key clue in at least three places, so missing one or two doesn't end the game.
- **Clues point forward, not just down.** Every clue should suggest a next place to go or a next person to press, and give the party somewhere they haven't yet been. A bloodless steer is a fact; a bloodless steer with the tracks leading to the old Vane place is a direction.
- **When they stall, have the dark act.** If the players run out of leads, don't wait — tick the clock. Another homestead falls, another body turns up, the thing grows bolder and leaves a fresh trail. The investigation that dries up on the players' end gets watered from the monster's. A stalled mystery is just a monster you haven't let move yet.
- **Let them be wrong productively.** A wrong theory, chased hard, should still cost or reveal something — the innocent man they suspected has his own secret, the dead end has a body in it. Reward the digging even when it digs in the wrong place.

THE HELD CARD

Keep one clue in your pocket with no fixed home. When the night stalls and nothing you planned has landed, spend it — the survivor remembers one more thing, the letter has a second page, the drifter finally talks. A

THE HELD CARD (CONT.)

floating clue you can drop anywhere is the surest cure for a table gone quiet, and the players never know it wasn't always there.

The Talking Fight

Half the dangerous moments in this game never draw a gun — the standoff talked down, the cultist questioned, the bargain weighed, the frightened witness coaxed into the truth. Run these with the same care you give a gunfight. A social conflict is not one roll; it is a scene with stakes, position, and degrees:

- **Set the stakes and the read first.** What does the NPC want, what would move them, and what will they never do? A man bargaining for his life talks differently than a fanatic who's made his peace with dying. Know the answer before the players start working on him.
- **Roll once it's uncertain, not to open.** Let the players talk — the actual words, the angle, the leverage they bring — and call for Persuade, Deceive, or Intimidate only when the outcome genuinely hangs and they've made their case. A good argument lowers the DC or grants the roll outright; a clumsy one raises it or forfeits it. Reward the play, not just the stat.
- **Narrate the four degrees here too.** A critical success turns the NPC further than hoped — they volunteer the next clue, become an ally, name a second name. A critical failure shuts the door and may make an enemy: the witness clams up for good, the marshal decides the party is the problem.
- **Some things cannot be rolled.** No check makes a loyal man betray his daughter or a Hollow Prophet abandon his Word. When the want is bedrock, say so — let the players find a different lever or a different door. A social roll is for moving the movable, not for overwriting who a person is.

III. Fear, Nerve & the Mark

The engine of dread, and the hand on its throttle.



*Fear is a coin, and you are a poor man. Spend it slow, and never the whole purse
at once.*

— FROM A KEEPER'S LEDGER



Nerve and the Mark are the truest hit points in this game, and you control the bleeding of both. The Player's Book tells the players what these tracks are. This chapter tells you when to spend them, how hard, and how to keep the horror from going slack on one side or lethal on the other. Misjudge this and the game becomes a plain western with monsters in it. Get it right and the table will not sleep easy.

When to Call a Dread Check

A **Dread Check** is a Will save against a Dread DC, made the first time a character truly confronts something that should not be. The operative word is *truly*. Do not call one for every corpse on a frontier thick with them. Call it when the ordinary world has visibly failed — when the corpse *moves*, when the shadow has no man to cast it, when a thing is wrong in a way a gun does not answer. Hold to three habits:

- **First sight, not every sight.** One check the first time a horror is met in a scene, not every round you describe it. Familiarity is its own slow mercy.
- **Once per kind.** The tenth walking corpse is not as terrible as the first. Don't tax Nerve for the same revelation twice in a night unless it escalates.

- **Earned, not sprung.** The check should follow a thing the players saw coming wrong. Dread you set up is dread; dread you ambush them with is just arithmetic.

The Dread DC Ladder

Choose the DC by what is actually witnessed, not by what it is named. A vampire glimpsed as a pale figure at the treeline is a lesser sight than the same vampire feeding. Pitch high the first time; let it settle as the night wears the players down.

The Sight	Dread DC	Nerve lost on a failed save
A fresh corpse, plainly murdered	10	1
A mutilation; a thing half-eaten	13	1d4
The walking dead; a true haunting	16	1d6
A thing from outside; the deep dark	20	1d10
A truth that unmakes the world	25	1d10 + a lasting Affliction

A **critical success** costs no Nerve and steadies that character against the same horror for the rest of the scene — reward the hard-bitten. A **critical failure** loses the Nerve and imposes *Frightened 1* at once. Remember the players begin each session at full Nerve (RES score + level); a tough hand might bank twelve or fifteen, a green and gentle soul barely six. Know your table's numbers before you start spending them.

Spending Dread Wisely

KEEPER'S EYE

Nerve is a budget for the whole night, not the first fight. If you bleed the party to zero by the second scene you have nowhere left to go and a table of broken characters doing chaos for an hour. Drain slow. Let small failures accumulate. Save the 1d10 sights for the reckoning, so the players walk into the climax already frayed — that is

KEEPER'S EYE (CONT.)

when a single failed save lands like a gunshot.

Running the Break

A character at **0 Nerve** breaks: roll on the Player's Book's table for an uncontrolled response, and they take a lasting Affliction. The thing to remember at the table is that a broken character is *not* benched — they are made dangerous, to themselves and to the souls beside them. Lean into it. A man firing wild at the threat and whatever's near it, a woman frozen useless while the dark closes — these are the moments the players will remember being scared. But keep it short. Hand control back the moment the immediate response plays out; a player narrating their own slow ruin is good horror, a player benched for an hour is a bored friend.

Afflictions — the Scars That Stay

When a soul breaks, or endures a sight that unmakes the world, it does not always come back whole. An **Affliction** is a lasting wound to the spirit — not a penalty the player chose, but a scar the dark left, and a thread for you to pull on. Roll one, or choose the one that bites deepest, whenever the rules call for it: a true Break, a horror beheld at DC 25, or a Mark step that should cost more than the rest.

d10	The Affliction	What it costs
1	The Shakes	–2 to anything fine or steady-handed while under any strain
2	Night Terrors	No Nerve returns from sleep alone — only by a fire, in company, or in drink
3	The Long Stare	–2 to be trusted or read by folk; they see the haunt on you

d10	The Affliction	What it costs
4	A Compulsion	A small rite — counting, salt, a rhyme — must be done, or be Shaken until it is
5	The Cold	Never quite warm again; -2 against cold and against fear
6	Faithless	The old comforts — prayer, ward, hymn — no longer steady you as they did
7	The Whisper	You hear it now; once a session it tells you something true, to earn a lie later
8	Brittle Nerve	Begin each session at -2 maximum Nerve until it heals
9	Marked in Dreams	The dark knows where you sleep; count your Taint exposure one step worse
10	The Hollow	A piece did not come back; -1 to one ability score until you are made whole

Afflictions heal slowly and seldom on their own. A full season of safety, a true sanctification, the care of an Alienist (a Sawbones art — Player's Book, Ch. V), or the facing-down of the very thing that caused it may lift one. Some will not fade until the larger wrong of the campaign is righted — and that is the point of them.

A KINDNESS

An Affliction is a story hook, not a punishment. Name it, let the table watch it work on their friend, and offer — somewhere down the trail — a hard road to its healing. A character who earned the Whisper and then silenced it has a tale worth more than the scare that gave it to them.

Giving Back Nerve

Nerve does not come back in the field. It returns at full only with the new session — a night survived, a fire, the company of the living. You may grant a small recovery (1d4) in play for a true respite: a safe night in a real bed, a hymn sung all the way through, whiskey shared with people who saw the same thing and lived. Never in sight of the dark, and never for merely waiting. The point is to make safety precious.

A Night's Worth of Dread — Worked

The hardest thing to feel for, starting out, is how much Nerve a night should cost. Too little and the horror never bites; too much and the party breaks in the second scene and spends the climax useless. Here is one full night budgeted for a hard-bitten 2nd-level character starting with **11 Nerve** (RES 9 + level 2), to show the shape of it:

The Bleeding of One Eli, Across One Session

- **Act One, the wrong note.** A mutilated steer, drained and wrong (DC 13). He saves — no loss. The dread is in the suspicion, not the tax. *Nerve: 11.*
- **Act Two, the first true sight.** The dead get up in the Pell barn (DC 16). He fails; loses 4. This is the night's hinge, and it should sting. *Nerve: 7.*
- **Act Two, the cellar.** The half-turned wife, pleading (DC 16 again, but once-per-kind — so no check for more Risen; this is a *new* horror, the living victim). He saves this time, hardened a little. *Nerve: 7.*
- **The ride to the mission.** No check — travel is for building dread, not taxing it. Let him stew. *Nerve: 7.*

The Bleeding of One Eli, Across One Session (cont.)

- **Act Three, the reckoning.** The Nightwalker's regard in the dark of the church (DC 16). He walks in already frayed at 7, and a failed save here — lose 1d6 — could drop him toward the break right as the climax peaks. *That* is the design: the night's worst sight lands on the thinnest Nerve.

Notice the rhythm: one save passed early to build confidence, one hard failure at the hinge, a quiet stretch to let it settle, and the deepest danger saved for the climax when the cushion is gone. A character who walks into the reckoning at full Nerve has had too easy a night; one who broke before it had too cruel a one. Aim to bring them to the climax frayed but standing, with just enough left that one bad roll matters.

READING THE ROOM

Watch the actual numbers as you go. If the party is bleeding faster than this — bad saves, a low-RES table — ease off: skip a check, let familiarity cover the next sight. If they're sailing through untouched, pitch the reckoning's DC higher or stack a second sight on it. The budget is a feel, not a formula, and the table tells you which way to lean.

The Mark

Nerve frays; the Mark *stains*. It is a track of six steps that does not heal on its own — it only ever waits. Grant it rarely and never cheaply, in exactly three cases:

- **Breaking utterly** — only on the rare roll (a 6 on the breaking table, a moment of terrible clarity) where the dark gets a hook in.
- **Reaching for the Old Dark** — when a character draws on power the world was not meant to hold: a hex worked, a bargain struck, a sign cut into living ground.
- **Touching the deep dark and surviving changed** — a Patron met and walked away from, a truth at DC 25 endured.

Each step costs the character something the table can feel — dogs that will not meet their eye, a chill, a hunger, a voice that gives good advice. At the sixth, the dark owns them, and they pass from a player's hands into yours. That is a campaign-ending fate and should take a campaign to reach. Make the Marked feel the road they're on long before its end.

Redemption exists — a true sacrifice, a sanctified ground held, a debt paid in full — but it is the rarest medicine in the country, and it should cost more than the bargain ever did.

The trouble, in play, is that "the table can feel it" is easy to write and hard to improvise at midnight. So here is the road, step by step — signs you can drop in without slowing the scene, each one a touch worse than the last:

Step	What the world does around them
1	Animals go uneasy — a dog growls low, a horse sidesteps, the cat leaves the room. Nothing a person would notice yet, but the beasts know.
2	A cold that travels with them; the fire seems to lean away. Folk feel it without naming it and sit a little farther off.
3	They know things they shouldn't — a stranger's grief, the bad card coming, the lie under a kind word. The good advice no one asked for, and the unease when it proves right.
4	A hunger, a habit, a thing they do now — salt they must throw, a count they must finish, a taste for the raw or the dark. The other players start to watch them.
5	The dark speaks to them plainly and offers, and the offers are good, and turning them down gets harder each time. They are useful now in ways that frighten the people who love them.
6	The road's end. What stands up wearing their face answers to you now, not the player — and it knows everything the character knew, including the party's soft places.

A WORD OF WARNING

Never hand a player the Mark as punishment for a bad roll. The Mark is for *choices*. A character cursed by a die is a victim; a character Marked by a decision they'd make again is a tragedy, and tragedy is the game.

IV. The Long Odds – Building the Fight

Balancing a gunfight that can kill, against monsters that should.



A fair fight is one the players can see the shape of before they walk into it. The rest is arithmetic and funerals.

— EB TUTTLE, TRAPPER



Combat in Blood & Grit is fast and thin. Blood totals are low, guns hit hard, and a first-level character can die in a single exchange they walked into wrong. That is a feature; this is a horror western, not a fantasy of heroes who soak ten wounds. Your job is to build fights that threaten without slaughtering by accident, and to know which dial to turn when the dice run cruel.

Threat by Tier

Every adversary in this book carries a **Tier**, a rough measure of its danger. Use this benchmark table to build a foe from nothing, reskin one, or judge whether the thing you're about to set loose is fair. The numbers are what a creature of that tier should hit and take; bend them a point or two for flavor.

Tier	Defense	Attack	Blood	Strong / Weak save	Damage / hit	Dread DC
I — a mean dog of a thing	13	+4	12	+6 / +2	1d6+2	— / 10– 13
II — a real threat	15	+6	22	+8 / +3	1d8+3	13
III — the night's monster	17	+9	40	+11 / +5	2d6+4	16
IV — an apex horror	20	+13	70	+15 / +8	2d8+6	20
V — a thing from outside	23	+17	110	+19 / +11	3d8+8	25

As a rough rule, a creature's Tier is a fair, dangerous fight for a party whose **level equals twice the Tier**: Tier I tests 1st–2nd level, Tier II around 4th, Tier III around 6th, and so on. A monster two Tiers above the party's reckoning is a thing to be fled, not fought — and good horror has plenty of those.

Budgeting a Fight

For a quick measure, give the party a budget of **4 points per character**. Spend it on foes:

- **A mook** (Tier at or below party-level–2): **1 point**.
- **An even foe** (Tier matching the rule above): **4 points**.
- **A standout** (one Tier above): **8 points**.

Spend the budget for a **standard** fight the party should win bloodied. Spend half for an **easy** one; spend half again over for a **hard** one; double it for a **deadly** one someone may not walk away from — and tell the fiction

so, with a sight, an omen, a dead man already on the ground, before the players commit.

Building a Threat from Scratch

The Bestiary holds a hundred and fifty things to fight, and the country always has one more. To make your own, work down this list — it takes about a minute.

Six Steps to a Monster

- **1. Pick the Tier.** Half the party's level, rounded toward danger. That is a fair, hard fight.
- **2. Copy the row.** Read Defense, attack, Blood, saves, damage, and Dread DC straight off the Threat-by-Tier table above. You now have a working monster.
- **3. Set its nature.** Choose the strong save: the dead and the cursed hold Will and Fortitude and fail Reflex; beasts hold Reflex and Fortitude and fail Will; the Old Dark holds Will above all.
- **4. Give it one Special.** The single thing the numbers don't say — it heals, it drains, it cannot be seen whole, it calls more of its kind. One is plenty; two makes a boss.
- **5. Give it one weakness.** The *Putting It Down* — the salt, the fire, the stake, the named truth. Every monster has its one thing, and learning it is the players' work.
- **6. Name the sight.** Decide what first seeing it costs in Nerve, and whether touching its power costs Mark. Then describe it so the table feels the Tier before they roll.

Worked in a breath — *a haunt-bound*, Tier II for a 4th-level party. Off the table: Defense 15, attack +6, Blood 22, saves +8 / +8 / +3, damage 1d8+3, Dread 13. Nature: a beast, so strong Reflex and Fortitude, weak Will. Special: it runs down whatever flees and never tires.

Weakness: it cannot cross a threshold freely given. Sight: DC 13, the green fire where its eyes should be. Two minutes, and the dark has a new hound.

The Gunfight

A few rulings will carry every shoot-out you run:

- **Range & cover.** A target behind cover adds +2 (partial) or +4 (good) to its Defense; a target with no cover in the open is a target the smart foe takes first. Sidearms past their range, and long guns up close, take the penalty in the Player's Book.
- **The draw.** When a fight breaks from a standoff, the side that meant to draw acts first; if both meant to, it's a Reflex contest. Reward the player who said "I keep my hand near my iron" in the talking.
- **Aim vs. volume.** A character may take the aim (a Beat to steady, then a surer shot) or pour it on (multiple shots at the rising Multiple Attack Penalty). Let the desperate spray and the patient aim; both are westerns.
- **The ambush.** A foe who strikes from true surprise gets a free round and, often, a Dread Check for the horror of it. This is how a Tier-III monster fairly threatens a higher party: it picks the ground.

Morale & the Flight of Men

Men are not monsters; they break and run. When a human foe is bloodied, leaderless, or has watched the dark take the fight out of their hands, call a morale check (a Will save against the situation). Bandits flee, surrender, or scatter. Monsters, as a rule, do not — and that difference is itself a horror the players will come to feel.

Pursuit

When something chases or is chased, run it as a short series of opposed checks — Ride, Athletics, Survival, whatever fits the ground — best of three deciding it, with each exchange a chance to describe the gap closing. Do not let a chase become a math problem; let it be a string of hard choices made at a gallop.

The Ground Is Half the Fight

Where a fight happens decides it more often than who's in it. A flat empty street is the duller battlefield in the country; give every reckoning a *map in the mind* — cover to break line of sight, high ground worth taking, a hazard to be used or feared, a chokepoint that funnels the dead. The players should always have a terrain decision to make, and the monster should always have one the players can turn against it.

- **Cover and concealment.** Cover stops bullets (+2 or +4 Defense, Ch. above); concealment only hides (a miss chance, a broken line of sight). Smoke, dark, and dust grant concealment — which the players can use as readily as the dark can, and a clever party will.
- **High ground and chokepoints.** The lip of the canyon, the top of the stairs, the doorway a swarm must come through one at a time. A party that seizes the choke turns a losing numbers-fight into a fair one; let them, and let the smart monster try to flank it.
- **The hazard in the room.** The lamp-oil, the dynamite, the rotten floor, the deep water, the edge. Seed one usable danger in every fight and the players will find ways to weaponize it you never imagined. The Drowned dragged onto dry land, the Hidebehind forced into the open, the swarm funneled past the open flame — these are the fights players remember.

KEEPER'S EYE

Before you run a fight, name three features of the ground out loud as you set the scene. Doing it before initiative means the players treat them as tools, not as things you invented to save them. A battlefield described is a battlefield played on; a blank room is just two rows of dice trading hits.

Running the Mob

A graveyard of Risen, a sounder of hogs, a pack run as one — many small foes can bog a table to a crawl if you roll each one in turn. Don't. A few tricks keep the swarm fast and frightening:

- **Run them in clumps.** Treat a group attacking the same target as one roll with a bonus, or one pool of damage, rather than six separate dice. Five Risen on one character is one attack at advantage that hits hard, not five turns of arithmetic.
- **One initiative for the lot.** The mob acts together on a single count. It moves together, strikes together, and you describe it as a tide, not as individuals — which is also how it should *feel*.
- **Give the swarm a heart.** The Gravecaller, the lead wolf, the relic at the center. A swarm with a source can be ended by reaching the source, which turns a grinding attrition fight into a tactical objective and gives the players a way to win that isn't "kill all forty." Most of the Bestiary's swarms are built this way on purpose — lean on it.
- **Let the mook die easy.** A foe at Tier party-level-2 should drop to one solid hit. Don't give the small things Blood totals that make the players saw through them; the threat of a mob is its numbers and its tirelessness, not the toughness of any one body.

When the Dice Turn Cruel

Combat in this game can kill, and sometimes it kills more than you meant. A run of bad saves, a monster crit, a plan gone wrong, and suddenly the whole party is bleeding out on the church floor. You have tools, and using them is not cheating — it is keeping the promise of fairness when the dice broke it:

- **Capture, don't kill.** Most monsters and all men have reasons to take rather than slay — a cult needs sacrifices, a Nightwalker needs cattle, an outlaw needs hostages. A downed party can wake bound in the cellar with everything to play for, which is far better horror than a sheet of dead characters anyway.
- **Bring the dawn.** Sunlight, a relief column, the storm breaking, the ally arriving — seed a clock that can rescue as easily as it can doom. A party pinned and dying saved by the gray of dawn, at the cost of the thing escaping, is a defeat that still moves the story.
- **Let the cost be the cost.** Sometimes someone dies, and that is the game keeping faith. When it comes, give it weight: the last word, the Grit spent to buy a friend's escape, the body that must be carried out or left behind. A death the table saw coming and could not stop is not a failure of the game — it is the dread made real, and it is why the rest will be remembered.

THE HONEST TPK

If the whole party falls fair — warned, bloodied, beaten by a thing they walked into eyes open — honor it. Don't fudge a total-party kill that the fiction earned; it cheapens every death that came before. But a TPK from a single freak run of dice, with no warning and no out, is the one you quietly soften, because it breaks the promise. Know the difference: a TPK the players can point at and say *we should have run* is a story; one they can only call bad luck is a betrayal.

A Hand at the Table

Rules read cold on the page. Here is the engine warm — a few beats of real play to show how the pieces move together. The Keeper's words are plain; the dice and rulings are in brackets.

Worked Example: The Pell Barn

Keeper: The barn door hangs open on a dark you can't see the back of, and something in there is breathing wet and slow. What do you do?

Eli: I ease up to the door and listen — can I tell what it is?

Keeper: Give me a Notice. [*Uncertain and consequential, so a roll; the dark hides a Risen, DC 15.*] ... A 19. [*Success.*] It's a man's shape, swaying, and the breathing isn't breathing at all — it's wind in a chest that doesn't work anymore. Then it turns, and its eyes catch your lantern, and they are the wrong color clean through. [*First true sight of the walking dead — a Dread Check, Will DC 16.*] Give me a Will save against the dread of it.

Eli: ...That's a 7. [*Failure: lose 1d6 Nerve, 4 rolled; Eli drops from 9 to 5.*]

Keeper: Your nerve goes out of you like water. You've seen dead men — never one that looked back. It comes off the wall toward you, arms rising. You have the time it takes to cross the barn.

Eli: I draw and put two in its chest. [*Two Beats: a shot, then a second at the Multiple Attack Penalty.*]

Keeper: First shot [*+5 vs Defense 12 — hits*] punches clean through, and the thing doesn't so much as flinch; it does not stop for pain. The second [*at -5 MAP*] goes wide as it closes. It's on you now.

Eli: I spend a Grit to make that second shot count — reroll. [*Grit spent; the reroll hits.*]

Worked Example: The Pell Barn (cont.)

Keeper: The second takes its jaw off and it staggers — but the Risen don't stop for ruin short of true ruin. It's still coming. Now you know what the salt and the lamp-oil in your saddlebag are *for*.

Notice what the engine did in those few lines: a check rolled only because failure was interesting; the degrees narrated, not just hit-or-miss; the first true horror taxed in Nerve; the action economy and the Multiple Attack Penalty shaping the gunfight; a Grit point spent to seize a moment; and a weakness seeded for the player to discover. Run every scene like this and the rules vanish into the story, which is where they belong.

V. The Bestiary & How to Use It

Where the monsters went, and how to set them loose.



Know the thing before you set it loose. A monster the Keeper does not understand is a monster that kills the wrong player.

— FROM A KEEPER'S LEDGER



The creatures once kept in this chapter have a book of their own now — *The Bestiary*, the third of these volumes, where a hundred and fifty of the things that walk the country are set down with the numbers to run them and the one hard truth that puts each one down. This chapter is the bridge: how to choose a horror, read its block, and wield it well. Keep the Bestiary at your elbow; this book tells you how to use it.

Reading a Stat Block

- **Tier** (I–V) is the measure of danger — a fair, hard fight for a party of twice that in levels (Ch. IV). **Defense** is the number to hit it; **Blood** is what it takes.
- **Saves** are Fortitude / Reflex / Will. **Attacks** give the bonus to hit and the damage on a hit; apply the Multiple Attack Penalty to extra strikes as a player would.
- **Dread** is the Will-save DC on first sight and the Nerve a failure costs (Ch. III). **Mark**, where it appears, is the soul-cost of touching the thing's power.
- **Putting It Down** is the secret — the weakness the players must learn, usually the hard way.

Choosing the Night's Monster

Pick by Tier first — the budget in Chapter IV tells you what is fair — then by the kind of fear you want. The Bestiary is sorted to help: the restless dead for sieges and grief; cursed beasts for the hunt; men and the shapes of men for paranoia and the gun; spirits and hauntings for the slow, helpless dread of a place; the wild and the weather for survival; and the Old Dark for the nights the players are meant only to survive.

Its last two chapters are sorted differently, and they are the ones a new Keeper reaches for last and should reach for first. The beasts of the living world and the hard men and hard country are sixty-five things that will maim a posse with nothing supernatural about them at all — a rustler with a running iron, a river in flood, a sow with cubs, a norther coming down at four in the afternoon. None of them costs a point of Nerve. That is the whole use of them: spend the first month of a campaign there, and the table learns that this country is dangerous on its own terms, that their guns work, and that you are dealing straight with them. Everything in the seven chapters above lands harder on a table that has been taught to expect an ordinary explanation.

Reskin Without Mercy

KEEPER'S EYE

A name is a costume. When the players have learned a thing's secret — the stake, the tell, the salted door — change its face *and* its secret, and let them learn again from nothing. The numbers in the Bestiary serve a dozen monsters each: the Pale Wolf's line runs any cursed pack, the Nightwalker's any blood-drinking dead.

Familiarity is the death of dread, and reskinning is its cure.

One Monster, Used Well

A single horror, glimpsed wrong three times before it is seen whole, frightens a table more than a parade of stat blocks ever will. Show the work it does before you show the thing: the drained steer, the wrong tracks, the survivor who will not speak. Let the players build the monster in their own heads, where it is always worse than anything on the page. The Bestiary gives you the body; your patience gives it the dread.

VI. Cursed Ground, Hazards & Bad Medicine

The dangers that have no eyes to shoot for.



The ground remembers what was done on it. Tell your players so early, and mean it, and they will come to fear the dirt itself.

— REV. A. JENSEN



Mark this chapter as the place your campaign quietly changes its nature. Up to here the players have fought things — and a thing that can be fought, however terrible, is still a western. From here on, some of what is wrong has no eyes to shoot for and no Blood to spend, and the game the players thought they were playing begins, by honest degrees, to be the other one. Do not announce it. Let them discover that the revolver has stopped being the answer, one unanswered shot at a time.

Not every threat in the country has a Blood total. Some of it is the ground itself, the weather, the long thirst, and the slow poison of places where the dark has soaked in. These hazards are how you threaten a party between monsters — and how you make a haunted place feel haunted before anything with teeth shows up.

Tainted Ground

Where blood was spilled in the dark's name, where a mine broke into the deep, where the veil has worn thin, the land itself takes a stain — and asks a toll of every living soul who lingers, monster or no. Run it as the *Taint* clock from the Player's Book (Chapter XII): for every three days on cursed ground, a Fortitude save (the body first) or Will (once it reaches the mind) against the ground's DC — **13** for soured earth, **16** for a blighted seat, **20** for a Patron's own ground. Fail and the Taint deepens a step; the four steps run from a souring sickness to a whisper that turns the soul onto the dark's errands. This is your tool for a haunted house that hurts to stay in even before the haunting starts. Wards, salt, and the right Provisions ease the DC; only true sanctification sheds it for good.

The Wrong House

A haunted place should fight the players quietly: doors that won't stay shut, a cold that lamps don't touch, a room that is wider inside than out. Spend Notice and Lore (Occult) checks (rolled in secret, Ch. II) to dole out the wrongness piece by piece. Keep a small clock for the haunting's escalation — cold, then movement, then a sight, then a reckoning — and tick it as the players pry where they shouldn't.

Cursed Objects

A thing carried out of a wrong place may carry the wrong with it. Use these sparingly; one good cursed object is a whole campaign thread.

The Object	The Gift	The Toll
A dead man's revolver	Never misfires; +1 to hit	It wants to be fired; Will save to holster it with a target in sight

The Object	The Gift	The Toll
A locket of hair	The wearer dreams true	The dreams are someone else's, and they are coming closer
A vein of cold silver	Coin that always spends	+1 Taint a week to whoever holds the purse
A prophet's bible	Reads the dark's signs at a glance	It reads you back; +1 Mark the day you trust it

When Players Dabble

BAD MEDICINE

Sooner or later a player works a sign, reads a rite, or takes a bargain. Let them — the Old Dark is in the Player's Book for a reason — but the dark always delivers exactly what was asked and never what was wanted, and the bill comes in Mark. A rite worked wrong (a failed check) does something, just not the something intended: it calls the wrong thing, or the right thing to the wrong place, or works on the caster. The fun is real and the cost is real. Hold to both.

The Plain Hazards of a Hard Country

Don't forget the mundane killers; on the frontier they do half your work. A killing thirst or cold (Fortitude, rising DC, Fatigued then Blood loss), a river crossing (Athletics DC 15, more in flood), a fall, a prairie fire, a fever in camp, a rattler in the bedroll. Set the DC off the ladder in Chapter II, let a critical failure cost real Blood, and remember that a party worn down by the road is a party already half-beaten when the dark finds them.

For when you need a number on the spot, here is the hard country priced out:

The Hazard	Save	On a failure
Killing thirst (per day, desert)	Fort, DC 13 rising +2/day	Fatigued, then 1d6 Blood and worsening
Killing cold (per night, exposed)	Fort, DC 13 rising +2/night	Fatigued, then 1d6 Blood; sleep risks worse
A bad fall (per 10 ft)	Ref, DC 15 to catch	1d6 Blood per 10 ft fallen
River in flood	Athletics, DC 18	Swept downstream; gear lost; drowning clock
Camp fever / bad water	Fort, DC 15	Sickened, –2 to all rolls until it breaks
Prairie fire / smoke	Ref to flee, Fort vs. smoke, DC 16	1d8 fire; choking and blind
Snakebite / spider	Fort, DC 15	1d6 and Enfeebled; worsens untreated
Quicksand / bog	Athletics, DC 15	Sinks a step each round; rope and aid needed
Bad laudanum / rotgut	Fort, DC 13	Stupefied; a poor choice in a crisis

A critical failure on any of these costs roughly double, or skips a step toward the worst the hazard can do. And the country stacks: a party that fails the thirst, then the fever, then meets the dark is a party you will barely need a monster to threaten.

Rites, Signs & the Working of the Craft

Sooner or later the players will want to *do* the dark's work themselves — cleanse a ground, ward a door, read a sign, work a rite out of a dead hexer's book. Here is how to run it without inventing it fresh each time. A working has four parts: a **cost** (time, materials, sometimes

Blood or Mark), a **check** (usually Lore (Occult), at a DC set by how far the working reaches), an **effect** on a success, and a **price** on a failure — because a botched rite never simply fizzles.

The Working	DC	Done right / Done wrong
Ward a threshold (salt, sign, prayer)	13	The dark cannot cross till dawn / it crosses, and knows you tried
Read a sign or omen aloud	15	A true answer / a true answer twisted, or a thing notices the reading
Cleanse a tainted spot	18	The ground eases a step / the taint flares and spreads to the cleanser
Lay a restless dead to rest	16	It rests / it wakes angry, or wakes its neighbors
Work a hex or bargain (the Old Dark)	20+	The dark delivers — and collects in Mark / it delivers to the wrong door, or onto the caster

THE BOTCHED RITE

The most important word above is *never fizzles*. A failed working does something — just not the something intended. It calls the wrong thing, or the right thing to the wrong place, or turns its effect on the one who worked it. This keeps the Craft genuinely frightening to use, which is exactly right: power over the dark should never feel safe, and a player who works a rite with a steady hand and a held breath is a player playing the game as built.

The Shape of a Bargain

The deepest working is the deal, and it deserves its own care because it is the engine of the Mark and half the tragedy of the game. When a player — or a desperate NPC — bargains with the Old Dark, hold to three rules and the deals will run themselves:

- **The dark gives exactly what was asked, and never what was wanted.** Wish the rival dead and he dies — and rises. Ask to save the child and she lives — changed. Read the letter of the request back to yourself and grant *that*, not the intent behind it. The gap between the two is where the horror lives.
- **The price is always Mark, and always more than it looks.** A small deal is one step; a large one, two or more; a deal to undo death or unmake a loss, the deepest stain the game allows. Name the cost honestly when asked — the dark does not hide its terms, because it doesn't need to.
- **Every bargain solves one problem and plants the next.** The deal that saves tonight should be the seed of a worse night later. A bargain with no future cost is just a magic item; a bargain that comes back wearing a debt is a story. And when the bill comes due, it often comes wearing the Tallyman's coat (see the Bestiary) — the collector who cannot be refused.

VII. Rewards & Reckonings

What to give, what to withhold, and the slow price of the dark.



*Give them little, and let it cost. A thing that came easy is a thing they will
spend without a prayer.*

— EULALIE ‘LUCKY’ DEVEREAUX



The country gives nothing away, but you must give the players *something* — growth, coin, the occasional grace — or the table goes hollow. The trick is to make every reward feel wrested from a hard place, and to let the dark's rewards always carry a hook.

Advancement

Run levels by **milestone**: advance the party when they close a chapter of the story — a monster put down, a place cleansed, a truth survived — not by a tally of kills. A new level every two or three sessions keeps the numbers climbing without outrunning the dread; a party that levels too fast soon shrugs off the horrors that should still chill them. When in doubt, slow down. A 3rd-level character in this game is a hardened, capable soul; a 7th is a legend the territory will remember; there is no need to climb past ten.

Grit

Grit is the players' small mercy — their hero points — and you are its other source. Hand a point, there at the table, for a deed of true courage, a moment of perfect character, or a line that makes the whole table go quiet. Be generous with it before a hard reckoning and the players will spend it bravely; hoard it and they will too, and someone will die clutching an unspent token. The point of Grit is to be spent.

Coin & Goods

Money is scarce and worth being scarce. Reward the players in things with stories — a dead outlaw's good rifle, a stake in a claim, a debt called in, a town's grudging gratitude that opens a door later — more than in loose dollars. A single box of silver shells, hard-won, is worth more dread-mileage than a saddlebag of gold, because the players will agonize over when to spend it.

The Dark's Wages

The Old Dark pays well and collects worse. When a Patron offers, let the offer be real and the price be Mark (Ch. III) — never a flat "no," which only makes the dark boring, but never a free "yes" either. The best bargains solve the immediate problem and plant the next one. A player who took the deal to save a friend, and would take it again, is exactly where the game wants them: one step further down a road they chose.

The Patrons at the Table

The Player's Book names six Patrons (Ch. VII) and wisely tells no more than a drifter's rumor of each. Here is the rest — how each one actually comes at a table of players, and when.

Thirty years behind a screen teaches one thing above all others about devils: an offer made on schedule is a mechanic, and an offer made at the exact wrong moment is a memory the table keeps for years. A Patron never simply appears. Each waits at a different door, and the players open every one of those doors themselves.

The Devourer — the door of want

It comes when the body is failing: the snowed-in pass, the tainted well, the wound going bad three days' ride from help. It has no voice and needs none — its offer arrives as meat. Game where no game should be, strength flooding into a starving frame, and only afterward the understanding of what was traded. Make the offer only after the players have said out loud what they might be willing to do to survive, and never a moment sooner — otherwise it is you tempting them, and not the country. Its progress shows at every camp thereafter: the served one eats first, eats most, and stops asking what the meat is. Let the other players notice before the one who took it does.

The Whisperer — the door of the question

It waits on curiosity, and its moment is the fact the players cannot reach: the name three sessions hunted, the hour the train passes, what is really under the church. It answers questions no one has asked aloud — a certainty arriving at the edge of sleep, sourceless and correct. The craft here is discipline: everything it says must be true, every time, or it dies as a horror at your table. Its price rides inside the gift — each answer carries one more truth the asker did not want and cannot now unknow. It is the Patron for the party's thinker, and it will find the one soul at your table who cannot leave a locked box alone.

The Cold Deep — the door of hurt

It comes to the grieving and the broken, and never during the horror — after. The shaking hour past midnight when it is over; the day after the funeral; the first camp after a soul has

Broken at 0 Nerve. It does not offer power. It offers relief — an end to the shaking — and relief is the hardest offer a player ever refuses on behalf of a hurting character. Its price is paid in subtraction, and you should run it that way: the character stops flinching, then stops weeping, then stops laughing. Roll no dice for any of it. Just let the table watch a friend go quiet.

The Long Trail — the door of the grave

It bargains exactly once, and its circumstance is a death — there at the table, with the body still warm and the players still silent. That is the hour the rider is on the ridge. One offer, in plain terms, no haggling; refused, it touches its hat brim and is gone, and it does not come back for that soul. Never offer twice — scarcity is the whole of its power, and the table must learn the refusal was real. If the deal is taken, remember that those it carries back come back a little wrong, and that the door it opened stays ajar: the returned soul sees the dusk rider now on every far ridge, and knows who it is waiting for.

The Thing Beneath the Mountain — the door of the strike

The one Patron that pays first and bargains after. Its circumstance is prosperity: the vein too rich for the ground it sits in, the claim sold suspiciously cheap, the town growing faster than any honest town grows. It seldom addresses the players at all — it works through the diggings and the money, and every dollar out of that ground is a signature on its paper. Run it as economics before you run it as horror: the players profit, the town booms, and only slowly does the arithmetic of what is waking underneath come due. It corrupts towns, not souls, and lets the town do the rest to the players.

The Red Sermon — the door of the flock

It rarely wants the players. It wants the crowd around them, and so it comes at the table sideways — through the revival tent, the new church, the charity that is feeding the hungry

and filling the pews. Its moment is the moment your players begin to love a congregation, a town, a good man in a pulpit. What it offers a soul is legitimate success — full pews, a town's love, a gospel that visibly works — which is why it is the Patron that catches Preachers and Prophets who set out meaning well. Fight it as a rival for people, not a monster in the dark: every session the players spend elsewhere, it gains a family, a deacon, a street. The horror is arithmetic, and the players can read it in the faces at the church socials.

THE VETERAN'S RULES

Four rules carry all six. A Patron makes its offer at the moment of weakness it owns and not before — hold the offer you have planned until the door is truly open, even if that takes a season. It almost never speaks in its own voice; it prefers heralds, dreams, signs, meat, money, and paperwork, and it is the more frightening for the indirection. One waking Patron is a campaign; two is a muddle — keep the others as rumors at the edge of the map. And the answer must always genuinely be allowed to be no. The Mark means something only because the player chose it — and a table that turns a Patron down flat has just told you, precisely, what they hold dearest. The dark was listening, and so were you.

Carrying the Marked

THE LONG FALL

A Marked character is a slow tragedy you are telling together. Show the steps — the dogs, the chill, the good advice no one asked for — and let the other players see them too, so the table feels the road. Offer redemption, but make it cost: a sacrifice, a ground held, a debt paid in full. And if a character reaches the sixth step, honor it — the dark owns them, they pass into your hands, and their fall becomes the next character's reason to ride. A Mark fully earned is one of the most memorable ends this game offers. Do not cheapen it, and do not flinch from it.

The Long Game

A single night you now know how to run. A campaign is a different animal — a slow tightening, where the country's wrongness spreads from one homestead to a county, and the same dark hand shows behind

a season of separate horrors. A few principles carry you from a one-night scare to a saga.

- **The dark has a shape.** Behind the monsters, set one patient cause — a Patron waking, a cult building toward its rite, a curse spreading like blight, a Marked man climbing. Each adventure is a symptom; the campaign is the disease, and the players are slowly learning its name.
- **Mark and Taint are the campaign's clock.** They only ever climb. A campaign is partly the story of who falls and who is pulled back — let the players feel the track filling over months, and let a hard-won step *backward* be one of the great victories the game can offer.
- **Run in seasons.** Three to five sessions make an arc: a wrong note, a deepening, a reckoning that closes one door and cracks open a worse one. End each arc with something the players changed and something the dark gained.
- **Let it end.** Every Blood & Grit campaign should be *able* to end — a last door closed for good, the cause undone, the country quieter than they found it — and the ending should cost. A west that can never be saved is a treadmill with skulls; a west the players bleed to save is a story.

THE RECURRING HAND

Give the campaign a face the players come to hate or pity — a Hollow Prophet who keeps rising, a Marshal going slowly Marked, a Patron's herald always one town ahead. Met across a season, a single antagonist does more for dread than a parade of monsters seen once and shot.

Between the Reckonings

The quiet stretches matter as much as the nights of blood. Downtime — the days or weeks between one reckoning and the next — is where characters heal, where Afflictions are worked on, where the players invest in the country that the dark will later threaten. Give them real things to do with it:

- **Mending body and nerve.** A true season of safety heals Blood fully and gives a chance at lifting one Affliction (a hard road, Ch. III). This is also when the doctor sets the bone right, the preacher hears the confession, the drink wears off. Make rest a place, not just a montage.
- **Putting down roots.** Let them buy the claim, court the widow, take the deputy's star, build the ranch. Every root they put down is a thing the dark can later threaten — and a reason they can't just ride away when it does. A character with nothing to lose is a character hard to frighten.
- **Working the leads.** Downtime is when the players chase the campaign's slow questions — research the old mission, write to the city for records, lean on a contact. Reward the digging with real threads. Let them *prepare*, sometimes, so the night they're ready feels earned.
- **The dark doesn't rest.** While they heal and build, tick the campaign clock. The cult gains a town, the Marked man falls another step, the herald rides closer. Downtime that costs the players nothing on the far side makes the world feel safe; let the price of resting be a little ground given.

Before You Run a Night — the Half-Hour Prep

A whole session needs less preparation than you'd fear, if you prepare the right things. Settle these and walk in ready:

- **The truth.** One paragraph: what's really happening, who's behind it, and what they want. If you can't say it in a breath, the players won't be able to either.
- **The clock.** What the dark is doing and how many steps until it gets there. Write the steps; tick them in play.

Before You Run a Night — the Half-Hour Prep (cont.)

- **Three wrong notes.** The omens you'll drop in Act One — the cold, the silence, the grave. Have more than you'll need.
- **The core clue, placed thrice.** The one thing the players must learn, and the three places they can learn it (Ch. II). Never gate it behind a roll.
- **The night's monster, read once.** Know its tier, its one Special, and its *Putting It Down* cold — so you run it right and the weakness is there to be found.
- **One held card.** A floating clue or complication in your pocket, for when the night stalls (Ch. II).

Six lines of preparation. Everything else — the faces, the talk, the ground — you can improvise off the tools in this book the moment the table needs it.

VIII. The Cast

The living souls of the country, made fast and run faster.

—

Every soul they meet wants something. Know the want and you can play the man — even one you made up a breath ago.

— MARSHAL T. COYLE

—

Most of what the players meet is people — frightened, greedy, kindly, complicit. You need to make them on the fly and run them without a stat block most of the time. Here is the quick way, and a roster of the common folk for when iron comes out.

An NPC in Three Lines

To improvise anyone the players turn to talk to, name three things and no more: **a want** (what they're after right now), **a tell** (a voice, a habit, a thing they always do), and **a secret** (what they're not saying). That is a whole person at the table. Reach for numbers only when the conversation turns to violence.

Reaction & Morale

When it matters how a stranger takes the players, roll a quick reaction: a Will or Presence contest, or a flat d20 read against the situation. And when a human foe is bloodied, leaderless, or staring at something no bullet fixes, call the morale save from Chapter IV. People in this country mostly want to live; let them act like it.

Who Is Actually Out Here

A Keeper who peoples the frontier out of the picture-shows will run a thinner country than the real one, and a duller game. The West of 1885 is the most mixed ground on the continent, and the mixing is not a footnote — it is the trade, the vocabulary, and the town.

Start with the work itself. The cattle business is Mexican before it is anything else, and every player at your table already speaks its language: the *lariat* is *la reata*, the *chaps* are *chaparreras*, the *remuda* (the herd of spare mounts), the *corral*, the *rodeo*, the *mustang* out of *mesteño*, and the *stampede* out of *estampida*. The vaquero taught the trade to everyone who came after him, and on any outfit worth riding for, the *segundo* — the man the trail boss actually listens to — is as likely to be a vaquero as not. Roughly one working hand in four on the great drives is Black or Mexican, and the outfit that says otherwise is lying to the census.

Then the rest of the county. Men and women freed by the war came west by the tens of thousands in the exodus of '79 and built whole towns of their own on the Kansas and Indian Territory grass, and their sons ride in the Ninth and Tenth Cavalry — the finest horse soldiers in the Territory, and the ones the Army sends first. The Chinese laid the Central Pacific through the Sierra, nine men in ten on that grade, and when the rails met they went into the mines, the laundries, the market gardens, the fishing boats, and the kitchen of every outfit that was lucky enough to hire one; three years back Congress shut the door behind them, and they are still here, and they are still building. New Mexican families have held their grant land since long before there was a United States to argue with, and are now watching a court in Santa Fe decide whether the paper their great-grandfathers signed still means anything. And the peoples who were here first are not one people: the Comanche and the Kiowa and the Chiricahua and the Diné and the Lakota and the Nez Perce and the Tohono O'odham want different things, speak unrelated languages, and have as little in common with one another as a Georgian has with a Swede.

KEEPER'S EYE

None of this needs a speech at your table; a speech would spoil it. It needs *names and jobs*. The doctor who sets a bone in Act One is Doc Wong, who trained in Guangzhou and again in San Francisco and is better than the man the Army sent. The segundo who reads the river and says *not here, further up* is Esperanza Ochoa, and she is right. The blacksmith the party will beg for a favor in Act Three is Jubal Deets, late of the Tenth, who has forgotten more about horses than anyone in the county ever knew. Give these people competence, a want, and a stake, and the country fills in behind them without a word of explanation. The one thing to avoid is the reverse: a face that is only there to be a face, or to be a victim, or to deliver a warning and leave. Everybody in the county has business of their own.

ON THE DARK, AND WHOSE IT IS

Two entries in the Bestiary — the Wendigo and the Skin-Walker — come out of Algonquian and Diné belief, and one comes out of Mexican and New Mexican belief, the Bruja. These are not folklore anybody made up for a game; they are things people hold, and in some cases hold sacred and do not discuss. Run them the way you would run something out of a neighbor's church: as terrible and real, never as costume, and never with an Indian or a Mexican character attached to explain it to the party. Where a horror comes out of a living tradition, the person who knows most about it should be the one the party is lucky to have on their side — and should be under no obligation to tell them everything.

Folk of the Frontier

Townfolk & Homesteaders

the people the dark comes for

DEFENSE 11 **BLOOD** 8 **SAVES** +2 / +1 / +2

ATTACKS whatever's to hand +2 (1d6); a shotgun by the door +3 (2d6, close).

NOTE Not fighters. Their role is to be saved, lost, lied to, or revealed as worse than they seemed. One named, liked homesteader in danger is worth more than any monster.

Frontier Lawman

the star, for what it's worth

DEFENSE 15 **BLOOD** 24 **SAVES** +5 / +5 / +5

ATTACKS revolver +6 (1d8+2); scattergun +6 (2d6+1, close); fists +5 (1d4+2).

NOTE Allies or obstacles. A good marshal is a fragile friend; a bad one is a Tier-II human threat with the town behind him. Either way the law was built for men, and breaks against the dark.

Hired Gun

a problem with a price

DEFENSE 16 **BLOOD** 30 **SAVES** +6 / +8 / +4

ATTACKS two shots a round +8 (1d8+3, range 80 ft); knife +7 (1d6+3). **The drop:** +2 and a die of damage from surprise or a won standoff.

NOTE A Tier-II/III duelist. Run him with cover and patience; he is what the players' gunslingers fear to meet on a clear street.

Doctor, Preacher & Drifter

the useful strangers

DEFENSE 12 **BLOOD** 14 **SAVES** +3 / +3 / +4

THE DOCTOR mends Blood and may know what the cursed man is dying of.

THE PREACHER may truly hold a line against the dark — or may be hollow (Ch. V).

THE DRIFTER knows the country, has seen the thing before, and will not say all of it.

NOTE These three are how you feed the players what they need to survive — and how you lie to them. Trust each at your peril.

The Town as a Character

Once a campaign settles into a place, the town stops being a backdrop and becomes a character in its own right — one the players will fight to save, and one the dark will use against them. Build it the way you build a person: with a want, a tell, and a secret. A town that wants the railroad will look the other way at a great deal; a town with a secret in its boot-hill will close ranks against questions. Give it a few standing fixtures and it runs itself:

- **A heart — the place they gather.** The saloon, the church, the store. This is where the players take the town's temperature and where you stage the public scene: the accusation, the town meeting, the funeral. When the heart goes wrong — the saloon gone silent, the church locked — the players feel it.
- **A handful of faces.** Four or five named locals with wants and tells (three lines each, above) are a whole town. Reuse them; let the players learn them. A named barkeep who dies in Act Three is worth more than a massacre of strangers.

- **A pressure already on it.** Debt, drought, a closing mine, a land-grab, an old feud. The dark rarely arrives to a happy town — it moves into the cracks already there, and the mundane pressure is what makes the supernatural one bite. The bank foreclosing is half the horror before a single corpse walks.
- **A way it can be lost.** Know what it looks like when the players fail this town — emptied, burned, hollowed, gone over to the dark. A town that can fall is a town worth saving, and the threat of its falling is most of why the players stay.

Factions & the Pull of the Country

A place with more than one power in it runs itself, because the powers push against each other and the players are caught in the middle. You don't need many — two or three standing interests turn a static town into a board in motion. Give each a **want**, a **lever** (what it can do to get its way), and a **line** (what it won't do — until it does):

- The **cattle baron** who owns the land and the law and wants the squatters gone — lever: hired guns and held notes; line: he won't burn folk out, until the dark gives him a reason.
- The **church** that knows what's in the old mission ground and wants it left buried — lever: the trust of the town; line: it won't lie outright, but it will let you believe wrong.
- The **railroad** that wants the route cleared and doesn't care what's in the way — lever: money and outside men; line: none worth the name, which is its own kind of horror.

Set the players among these and every choice has a cost on some other ledger. Help the baron and the church turns cold; trust the church and the railroad moves against you. The dark's genius is to be the secret behind one of them, so that the faction the players sided with was the wrong one all along.

KEEPER'S EYE

Don't script how the factions resolve — let the players' choices tip the board, and play each power honestly

KEEPER'S EYE (CONT.)

toward its want. A faction that reacts to what the players actually do, rather than waiting in a box for its scene, is the difference between a living country and a diorama. Move them between sessions, off-screen, and let the players walk back into a town that changed while they were gone.

IX. A First Reckoning

A complete first night, built to teach the game while it scares the table.



The first night is a promise. Keep it honest and keep it frightening, and they will follow you into a hundred more.

— FROM A KEEPER'S LEDGER



The *Salt at Coffin Wells* is a one-session adventure for a fresh party of 1st-level characters. It is built to do the thing a first session most often fails to do: open as an honest western, turn the wrong note slowly, and teach Nerve, the Mark, and the gun all in one night — with every monster you need drawn from the Bestiary so you never have to leave this book. Read it once; run it loose.

The Truth (for the Keeper alone)

Coffin Wells is a dying cattle town. Six weeks ago its banker, **Josiah Vane**, ruined and desperate, dug up the wrong grave on the old mission ground east of town — the grave of something the Spanish padres had staked and salted a century back. He meant to rob it of rumored silver. He woke a **Nightwalker** instead, and struck a bargain to save his own neck: blood for the town, fed to it quietly, in trade for being spared and made rich.

The "fever" taking the outlying homesteads is the Nightwalker feeding, and the freshly dead are beginning to rise as **Risen**. Vane is in too deep to stop and too afraid to

The Truth (for the Keeper alone) (cont.)

confess. **The clock:** the Nightwalker grows stronger each night it feeds; in four nights it will be past any stake, and Coffin Wells will be a town of the dead.

The Hook

Any reason that gets the party to Coffin Wells serves — a job driving cattle, a name on a wanted dodger, a letter from kin gone quiet, simple thirst at the end of a long ride. They arrive at dusk to a town with its shutters already closed against the dark, and a marshal who wants them gone by morning.

Act One — The Ordinary West

Let it be a real town for a scene. The saloon, the wary barkeep, the talk of "fever" out at the homesteads, the banker Vane buying a round and steering the talk away. Plant the wrong notes gently: the new graves at the boot-hill are *disturbed*; the dogs won't go east; a homesteader's wife says her husband came home three days after they buried him, and won't say more. **No monster yet.** End the act when the party rides out to the Pell homestead to look into the fever — the marshal's reluctant errand, or their own curiosity.

Act Two — The Wrong Note Answers

The Pell place is dark, the door open, the supper cold on the table. Here the players meet the dead getting up: **2–3 Risen** (Tier I), one of them the buried husband. **This is the first Dread Check** — DC 16, 1d6 Nerve — and their first lesson that some foes do not stop. Pitch it as a fair, frightening fight they can win with fire and a cool head; let someone learn what salt and a shotgun do. In the cellar they find the wife, bled and half-turned, and a

choice that teaches the Cursed Man's lesson in miniature: a mercy, or a hope that costs them. A scrap of mission silver in the husband's pocket points east, to the old church.

TEACHING THE ENGINE

This is the act where Nerve becomes real to the players. Call the Dread Check out loud, name the save, let a failure sting. If someone breaks, lean in briefly, then hand control back. By the end of Act Two the party should be frayed, low on Nerve, and starting to understand that this is not the western they thought they rode into.

Act Three — The Reckoning

The trail leads to the ruined mission and the opened grave. Vane is here at the climax — come to feed it, or to beg it, or dragged by the players' questioning — and the **Nightwalker** (Tier III) is the night's monster. Run the confrontation in the dark of the church: the Dread regard, the cold, the thing climbing the walls. The players cannot simply out-shoot it; they must *learn its weakness in the moment* — the stake, the salt, the coming dawn — from the padres' carvings on the wall, a clue in Vane's stolen papers, or the drifter's half-told warning if you planted one. Give them the tools and let them put the pieces together under fire. That solved puzzle, won at the edge of breaking, is the night's triumph.

The Box

However it ends, give it weight. If they stake and burn the thing and salt the grave, Coffin Wells lives, and the players have their first legend — and a banker to hang or pity. If Vane gets away, or the dawn comes too late, leave a thread: a town half-saved, a survivor who saw too much, a debt the dark considers unpaid. And whatever happened to the Pell wife in that cellar should follow at least one character into the next night's dreams. That is how you end a first reckoning: with the floor dropped, and the players already wondering what else the country has been waiting in the quiet to show them.

Scaling the Night

- **A bigger or bolder party:** add Risen in Act Two, give Vane a pair of desperate Road Agents as hired guards in Act Three, and let the Nightwalker open with an ambush.
- **A smaller or greener party:** fewer Risen, and let the church carvings spell out the weakness plainly. The Nightwalker can be *fed and slow* the first night — Defense 16, no regard — if the party reaches it early.
- **If the dice turn cruel:** the dawn is always one scene away, and sunlight is the great equalizer. A party pinned and dying can be saved by the sky going gray — at the cost of the thing escaping to be hunted another night.

X. A Second Reckoning

A second first night — quieter, crueler, and won with the eyes, not the gun.



The gun is not always the answer — the craft is teaching them that before the answer they reach for gets someone killed.

— MARSHAL T. COYLE



A *Face Not His Own* is a one-session adventure for 1st–2nd level characters, and a deliberate change of key from *The Salt at Coffin Wells*. Where the first reckoning is a siege you shoot your way out of, this is a locked-room of paranoia where the players cannot win by drawing first — the monster is already inside, already wearing a friend's face, and the only way out is to **see** the wrong thing before it sees its chance. Run it to teach a hard lesson: in this country, the gun is not always the answer, and sometimes the most dangerous figure at the table is the one smiling back.

The Truth (for the Keeper alone)

Saltlick Station is a lonely stage relay a hard day from anywhere. Two weeks ago a **Skin-Walker** (Tier III, Ch. V) killed the hostler, **Eli Stroud**, and put on his skin. It has been thinning the travelers who stop here ever since, learning to pass for a man — and it is getting good at it.

Tonight a blue norther closes the trail and strands the party at the station overnight, alongside a handful of other souls. The thing means to take them one at a time through

The Truth (for the Keeper alone) (cont.)

the long dark, and to ride out at dawn wearing whichever new face is freshest. **The clock:** it acts once a night-watch — isolating, mimicking, killing — and by the gray of dawn the storm lifts and it intends to be gone. It will not stand and fight unless cornered and exposed; a stand-up brawl with it is how a low party dies, and you should let the fiction warn them.

The Hook

The party is on the trail — carrying mail, chasing a name, or just riding through — when the sky goes the color of a bruise and the wind picks up teeth. Saltlick Station is the only roof for twenty miles. They make it in as the storm closes the world down to white and wind. The doors are barred behind them. No one is leaving till it breaks.

The Souls Under the Roof

Besides the party, give the station a handful of NPCs (Ch. VIII numbers) — one of whom is the thing. Name them, give each a want and a tell, and let the players get comfortable before anything goes wrong:

- **"Eli," the hostler** — easy, helpful, knows the horses by name. *This is the Skin-Walker.* Play him warm and useful; let the players come to like him.
- **Mrs. Pruitt**, who cooks and runs the place — sharp, tired, has noticed Eli's "been off" since his fever but can't say how.
- **Foss**, a drummer with a wagon of patent tonics — nervous, talkative, the first to panic and the first to accuse.

- **Calla**, a quiet traveler with a good gun and a hard eye — suspicious of everyone, the party included; a useful red herring.

Act One — The Wrong Note Among Friends

Let the first hour be ordinary and even warm: a fire, a meal, the storm shut outside. Then plant the tells, one at a time, on **secret** Notice and Lore (Occult) checks (Ch. II) so the players are never sure what's real:

- The station dog will not come inside while Eli is in the room, and watches him without blinking.
- The horses go wall-eyed and scream when Eli enters the barn, though he's gentled them for years.
- By firelight, for half a breath, Eli's eyes catch the light the way an animal's do.
- Eli misremembers a thing the real Eli would know cold — or knows a thing he shouldn't.
- The cracked mirror by the door shows his reflection a beat behind him, once, if someone's watching.

TEACHING THE ENGINE

This is the act of *doubt*. Roll the tells in secret so a failed check leaves the player unsure whether they saw nothing or merely missed it. No Dread Check yet — save it. The horror here is social, not supernatural: the slow certainty that one of these faces is wrong, and the cost of guessing.

Act Two — The First Taking

On the deepest watch of the night, the thing makes its move: someone goes out to the barn for wood or a horse and does not come back — or is found at the edge of the lamplight, wrong. **This is the first Dread Check** (DC 16, 1d6 — the walking dead's tier of wrongness, for a body left as the Skin-Walker leaves them). Now the paranoia turns to fear. The thing's

game is to sow doubt: it mimics a voice from the dark, apes another's manner, points the finger first. The players must put the tells together and name the monster — and the awful turn of the screw is that they might name the wrong soul, and do murder, and learn the truth only after. Let accusations have weight. Let Calla nearly get shot. The night should cost them trust before it costs them blood.

Act Three — The Tell Made Plain

The climax is not a slugging match — a Tier-III Skin-Walker will kill a green party in a fair fight, and the fiction should make that plain (let it shrug off a solid hit early, move wrong, be *fast*). The win is to **force the tell into the open** and then **ward or break** the thing: hold it before the mirror so all can see what wears Eli's face; drag it into the firelight; lay the line of **ash and bone** across the threshold it cannot cross; and finish it with a bullet that has been **prayed over or cast of silver** (the Player's Book, Ch. X, and the Bestiary entry). Give the players the pieces — Mrs. Pruitt's grandmother's warding rhyme, a silver crucifix, a box of blessed shot in the strongbox — and let them assemble the answer under pressure. A monster *exposed and cornered* is killable; a monster fought blind is not. That difference is the whole adventure.

The Box

If they expose it and end it, the storm breaks toward dawn and the survivors ride out into a clean cold morning — never quite sure, after this, of a stranger's face in poor light. If it slips away into the white, then it is out there still, wearing someone the players trusted, and it knows their faces now. Either way, leave one small wrong note at the end — a reflection that lags, a dog that growls at a friend — and let the table wonder.

Scaling the Night

- **A bolder party:** let the Skin-Walker take a second NPC, and have it wear a *player's* absent character or a beloved face in the finale, so the killing blow costs something.
- **A greener party:** stack the tells thick and obvious, hand them the warding rhyme early, and let the cornered thing be already wounded from its last kill (start it bloodied). The mirror alone can drive it out if they think to use it.
- **If the dice turn cruel:** the storm is the clock and the mercy both — a party that barricades well and survives till the norther breaks can drive the thing out into the dawn rather than kill it, and live to hunt it another night.

XI. The Keeper's Year

Carrying the dark from a single night to a saga, and three to set you riding.



*A single night is a campfire tale. A year of them, told right, is the country itself
— and the players will swear they lived there.*

— FROM A KEEPER'S LEDGER



A one-night scare you now know how to run. The two reckonings before this chapter taught the siege and the locked room; the rest of this book taught the engine under them. This chapter is the long view — how to take all of it and run not a night but a *year*, where the country's wrongness has a shape, the players have a stake, and the dark they close the door on in the spring is the same dark that comes back in the fall wearing a worse face. Here is the frame, the rhythm, and three campaigns ready to ride.

The Three Frames

Most Blood & Grit campaigns sit in one of three shapes. Pick the one that fits your table and the dark almost organizes itself.

- **The Haunted County.** The players root in one place — a town, a valley, a stretch of trail — and defend it across a year as the dark closes in from every side. Strength: the town becomes a character they bleed to save (Ch. VIII), and every loss lands. Run it when your table wants attachment, stakes, and a place to call theirs.

- **The Long Trail.** The players ride, drifting town to town, each a self-contained reckoning, with a single thread pulling them onward — a name, a debt, a thing they're chasing or that's chasing them. Strength: variety and momentum; you can run nearly any one-shot as a stop on the road. Run it when your table likes the new and the open, and a campaign that's a journey, not a siege.
- **The Closing Circle.** The players know, from early, what the great dark is — the Patron waking, the cult's rite, the Wound widening — and the whole campaign is the race to close it before it finishes. Strength: a clear, mounting dread with a real ending in sight. Run it when your table wants a story with a spine and a climax they can see coming for them.

The Rhythm of a Year

Whatever the frame, the year breathes in arcs — three to five sessions each, a wrong note to a reckoning — and the arcs stack into seasons. Hold to a shape and the campaign paces itself:

- **The Opening (1–2 arcs).** Establish the ordinary west, the place and people, the first taste of the dark. The players learn the engine and put down roots. End it with a reckoning that reveals there's something *behind* the first monster.
- **The Deepening (2–3 arcs).** The pattern emerges; the same dark hand shows behind separate horrors. Mark and Taint climb. The players invest, lose someone or something, and start to grasp the shape of the larger wrong. Raise the stakes each arc.
- **The Reckoning (1–2 arcs).** The great dark moves openly. Old threads pay off, the recurring hand is met at last, and the players spend everything they've built to close the door for good — at a price. End it. A campaign that can end, and does, is a story; one that can't is a treadmill (Ch. VII).

THE THROUGHLINE

Whatever frame you choose, run one thread the whole way — a Patron, a cult, a curse, a Marked soul climbing. Each session is a symptom; the campaign is the disease, slowly named. Drop a clue toward the throughline in nearly every night, even the standalone ones, and by the end the players will feel the whole year was one story tightening — because it was.

Three Campaigns, Ready to Ride

Each of these is a year in a paragraph — a frame, a throughline, a clock, and the door that closes it. Take one whole, or strip it for parts.

The Salt Valley — a Haunted Country

The frame: the players settle in Saltlick Valley, a hard ranching country ringed by old mission ground. **The throughline:** a century ago the padres staked and salted a Patron's reaching hand into the valley floor; the railroad's blasting has cracked the seal, and the dark is leaking back, one homestead at a time. **The clock:** each season the unhallowed ground spreads a ranch further, the dead get bolder, and the valley's folk turn on each other (the Drought-Bringer's despair, made political). **The door:** the players must find what the padres did, pay the price to seal the hand again — and decide what the railroad, and the future, is worth. **Bestiary:** Risen and the Gravecaller early; the Veinwork in the railroad cut; the Servant of the Deep Dark at the seal; the Tallyman for whoever bargained.

The Name in the Dust — a Long Trail

The frame: the players ride a circuit of frontier towns, hunting (or hunted by) a man who can't be killed wrong. **The throughline:** the Deathless Gun is collecting

The Name in the Dust — a Long Trail (cont.)

something across the territory — a name, a debt, a string of fair duels — and every town he's passed through has a fresh grave and a piece of the truth. **The clock:** he's always one town ahead, and what he's gathering nears completion with each duel he wins. **The door:** the players learn his bargain and its terms, and someone among them must meet him fair, alone, in the open — the one way he can fall. **Bestiary:** a different reckoning each town (the Hexed Beast, the Hanging Judge, the Mesmerist), with the Deathless Gun's shadow over all, and the Crossroads Man behind the bargain he made.

The Widening Dark — a Closing Circle

The frame: from the first night, the players know a Wound is opening in the deep country and the sky is starting to look back. **The throughline:** a cult of the Open Eye is working, season by season, to tear the veil wide — and the players have until it's done. **The clock:** a six-step rite across the campaign; each arc the players can disrupt a step, or arrive too late and watch it turn. **The door:** reach the Wound before it widens past closing, and pay what closing it costs — a rite undone, a sacrifice given right, a name struck out. **Bestiary:** the Flock and the Hollow Prophet as the cult's body; the Pallid Herald and the Faceless Rider as its heralds; the Wound in the World and the Eye Between Stars at the end of everything.

A LAST WORD

You will run more of this game than you plan and less than you hope, and that is the way of every table. Don't hoard your best ideas for a someday campaign — spend them. Let the players surprise you, and surprise them back. Keep the watch, bleed the Nerve slow, and salt the grave. The country was here before them and will be here after, and for a year you get to be its voice in the dark. Make it worth the night.

XII. The Country in Your Pocket

Rollable tables for the moment the players ride somewhere you haven't built yet.



Preparation is a fine horse, but the players will shoot it in the first act. Learn to walk.

— FROM A KEEPER'S LEDGER



Every Keeper meets the moment: the players turn their horses off the road you prepared and ask what's over the next rise. This chapter is for that moment. Roll, read, and ride on — a town in three rolls, a face in four, a rumor, a night on the trail, a find, an omen. Nothing here needs preparation, and everything here is a seed you can grow later if the players take root in it.

A Town in Three Rolls

Roll a d20 twice for the name (front, then back), then a d12 each for what ails it and what it hides.

d20	Front	Back
1	Dry	Creek
2	Salt	Wells
3	Coffin	Gulch

d20	Front	Back
4	Providence	Flats
5	Bitter	Springs
6	Lament	Crossing
7	Redemption	Ridge
8	Widow's	Hollow
9	Gallows	Bend
10	Mercy	Station
11	Rattle	Rock
12	Perdition	Fork
13	Cinder	Camp
14	Hope	Landing
15	Blackwater	Draw
16	Furnace	Mesa
17	Lonesome	Butte
18	Grave	City (pop. 61)
19	Judgment	Junction
20	Last	Chance

d12	What ails it (plain to see)	What it hides (dig for it)
1	The mine is played out and the men aren't leaving	The last shift never came up, and no one went looking
2	Drought; the wells are down to mud	The one sweet well belongs to a man who prays to something for it
3	The railroad is coming through — or past	The survey line runs through ground the town swore never to open
4	Stock dying; wolves blamed	The stock is drained, not eaten, and the wolves left weeks ago
5	A feud between the two big families	Both patriarchs answer to the same buried bargain
6	The church burned last spring	The congregation set the fire themselves, and won't say why
7	Too many fresh graves for a town this size	Fewer bodies in them than headstones over them
8	The marshal is a drunk or a coward	He saw what runs this town and was left alive to keep order anyway
9	Nobody will ride the north road after dark	Someone feeds the north road, on a schedule, to keep it satisfied
10	A revival tent has half the town in it every night	The preacher's sermons are true, word for word, and getting truer
11	Children have gone missing — two this season	They come back, eventually. Changed. The town pretends not to see.
12	The town is emptying; wagons leave weekly	The ones who leave are never heard from again, and the road east shows no tracks

A Face in Four Rolls

A d20 for the given name, a d20 for the surname, a d12 for what they want, a d12 for their tell.

d20	Given	Surname	d20	Given	Surname
1	Amos	Ashford	11	Lucinda	McCready
2	Beulah	Blackwood	12	Merritt	Nye
3	Cassius	Cole	13	Nora	Oakes
4	Dorothea	Danvers	14	Obadiah	Pruitt
5	Ezekiel	Eastman	15	Prudence	Quirk
6	Flora	Fenn	16	Roscoe	Reyes
7	Gideon	Grady	17	Salome	Slade
8	Hattie	Holloway	18	Thaddeus	Tanner
9	Isaiah	Ives	19	Una	Vane
10	Josephine	Krieg	20	Wilbur	Whitlock

d12	What they want	Their tell
1	Money, plainly and now	Counts things — coins, exits, your party
2	To leave this town and can't	Always faces the door
3	Their child back — from debt, drink, or the dark	Wears something of the child's, worried smooth
4	Revenge dressed up as justice	Smiles only when someone else is hurting

d12	What they want	Their tell
5	To confess something to anyone safe	Starts sentences and buries them
6	Protection, and won't say from what	Salt in every pocket; checks windows at dusk
7	To be believed, at last	Talks too fast, brings written proof no one reads
8	The party gone by morning	Overly helpful with directions out of town
9	To sell you something you shouldn't buy	Handles the merchandise with gloves
10	Company; they are desperately lonely	Keeps refilling your glass unasked
11	To keep a promise made to the dead	Visits the boneyard daily, same hour
12	What the dark promised them — almost paid off now	The animals won't come near; they've stopped noticing

Bar Talk — a d20 of Rumors

Half of these are true in any given town. You decide which half after the players choose one to chase.

d20	What they're saying	d20	What they're saying
1	The stage hasn't come in two weeks; the road's fine	11	The new preacher don't cast a shadow at evening service
2	Old Krieg pays double for night work at his place; nobody goes twice	12	They hanged the wrong man in '81 and the right one still buys drinks here
3	A white bison was seen on the flats; the tribes have gone quiet about it	13	The mine took on a new vein; the ore hums if you hold it

d20	What they're saying	d20	What they're saying
4	A whole wagon train wintered at the pass and never came down	14	The Vane girl came back from the river three days after she drowned
5	There's a gunfighter in the territory can't be killed; ask at the faro table	15	Cattle on the north range born wrong this spring — every one
6	The Army's buying salt by the wagonload and won't say why	16	A woman weeps along the creek at night; don't answer her
7	Doc's been ordering twice the laudanum for half the patients	17	The bounty on the Sorrel Gang doubled; the last posse's horses came home alone
8	Something's been opening graves — from underneath	18	There's a door in the mesa the old people painted shut
9	The railroad man buys land nobody'd want at prices nobody'd refuse	19	The marshal burned a bundle of letters the night the judge died
10	A traveling show is a day behind you on the road; folk vanish where it plays	20	It's quiet lately. Too quiet. Even the coyotes have moved on.

The Trail — d12 by Day, d12 by Night

d12	By day	By night
1	Weather turning — a wall of it, hours off	The fire won't take, and the wood is dry
2	Tracks crossing yours: shod horses, moving fast, one bleeding	A light on the ridge that answers when you cover yours
3	Buzzards, a mile off, patient	The horses wake you, staring at the same nothing

d12	By day	By night
4	A homestead: door open, table set, nobody	Singing, far off, in a language nobody owns to knowing
5	Fence line cut — from the outside	One of the party talks in their sleep, answering questions
6	A stranger afoot, no water, won't say from where	Something big circles the camp once, upwind, and leaves
7	Fresh grave by the trail, marker turned face-down	The stars are wrong over one quarter of the sky
8	Good water, good grass — and old bones in the reeds	A child's voice asks to share the fire. There is no child.
9	A drummer's wagon, wares half-price, seller in a hurry	Dawn is an hour late. Nobody's watch agrees.
10	Smoke ahead — too much for a campfire, too little for a town	Every snare and picket is undone, gently, from within
11	The shortcut everyone knows about; nobody's used it in a year	Frost, in August, in the shape of footprints
12	A rider pacing you on the far ridge all afternoon	You wake where you camped. The ashes are a week cold.

Plunder & Finds — a d12

d12	The find
1	\$2d20 in mixed coin, some of it minted nowhere you know
2	A good horse, saddled, patient, waiting — branded to a dead man's outfit

d12	The find
3	A fine revolver with eleven notches and a name scratched out
4	Letters home, unsent, that explain everything if read in order
5	A doctor's bag, complete, monogrammed, one instrument missing
6	A claim deed, legal and current, to ground the locals won't name
7	A silver crucifix, heavy, bent nearly double by hand
8	Tintypes of strangers — and on a second look, one of a party member
9	A journal, sane for forty pages, then diagrams
10	Trade goods: powder, salt, coffee — worth \$30 to the right town, questions to the wrong one
11	A child's doll, new, dry, forty miles from anywhere
12	A key of black iron, cold in any weather; you'll know the lock when you see it

Wrong Notes — a d20 of Omens

For seasoning any scene that needs a chill without a check. One at a time; let them accumulate.

d20	The wrong note	d20	The wrong note
1	The birds stop, all at once, mid-phrase	11	A rocking chair, rocking, wind or no
2	Milk gone sour in the pail, morning-fresh	12	The dog won't cross a particular floorboard
3	Every clock in the house stopped at the same minute	13	Fresh flowers on a grave nobody tends

d20	The wrong note	d20	The wrong note
4	A cold spot the width of a doorway, in open ground	14	The well rope is wet. The bucket is dry.
5	Handprints on the window. Outside. Second floor.	15	A hymn hummed from the barn; the barn is empty
6	The horses are watching something walk the fence line	16	Salt spilled across every sill, from inside
7	Seven crows on the wire, facing the house	17	The family Bible open to a page that's been cut out
8	A smell of lightning on a clear day	18	Your reflection is a half-second behind in the shaving glass
9	Wet bootprints from the creek to the door, none returning	19	The baby laughs at the empty corner, every evening, same time
10	The candle flames all lean the same direction; there is no draft	20	Somewhere out on the flats, a church bell. There is no church.

THE SEED RULE

Anything you roll here that makes the table lean forward is no longer a random result — it is now part of the campaign. Write it down, give it a cause, and hang a thread from it (Ch. II). The tables are not filler; they are an oracle, and the players will treat whatever comes out of them as deliberate. Let them be right.

XIII. Perdition Basin

One county, drawn whole and keyed — the worked example of a Haunted Year.



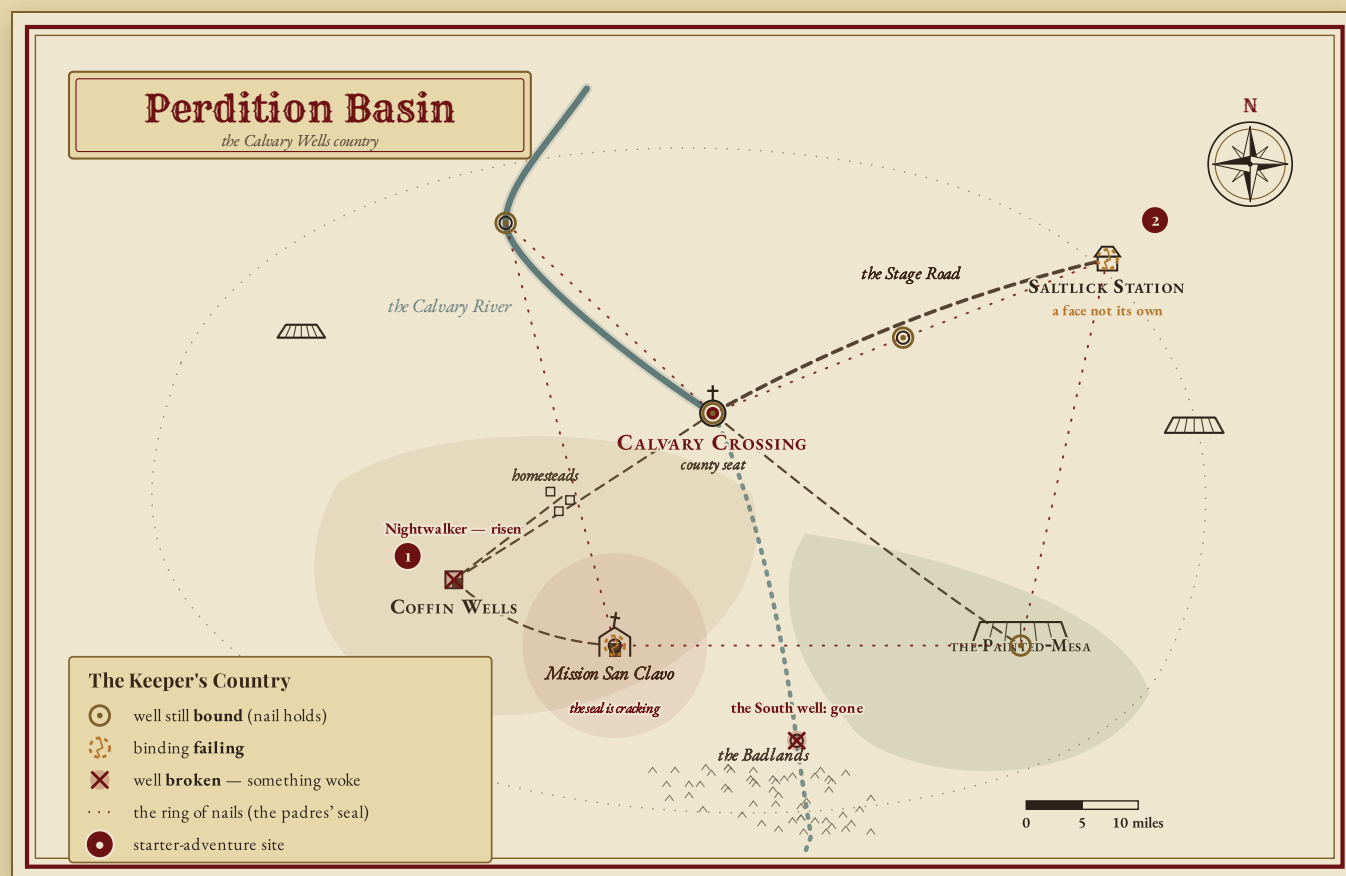
I have mapped every well in this country and named every town. It is the wells I no longer sleep for. A town is only people. A well is a door, and someone has been leaving them open.

— FROM THE FIELD-BOOKS OF N. ASHBY, NATURALIST



Submitted for your consideration, then: one county, surveyed and staked, whole enough to hold a year. It begins as every good lie in this country begins — with the truth. A river, a bank, a stage road, a marshal, cattle at fair prices. Nothing in Perdition Basin will read as anything but a western until the third or fourth night, and that is its design and its lesson in one: the slow burn is not a trick you play on the county. It is what the county is.

Everything before this chapter handed you parts: the engine, the monsters, the craft, two finished nights, and the frame for stringing nights into a year. This chapter spends all of it in one place. **Perdition Basin** is a whole county — mapped, keyed, and built so you can open this book and run. It is the home ground of both reckonings you already have: *The Salt at Coffin Wells* (Ch. IX) and *A Face Not His Own* (Ch. X). Run them here and they stop being two one-shots and become the first two nights of one story — the *Haunted County* of Ch. XI, drawn out and given a map. Take it whole, or strip it for parts and hang them on a country of your own.



Perdition Basin — the same country with its wounds shown: the failing seal, and what each broken well let up.

The Truth of the Basin

Perdition Basin is a low, dry bowl of a country, its life strung along the failing **Calvary River** and the scattered wells and springs that are the only sure water for a hard day's ride in any direction. That is the honest map, and it is the one your players will draw. Here is the one they will not: **the water rises from something beneath, and the something is awake.**

A century ago the Franciscan padres of **Mission San Clavo** learned it — from the ground, from the dead that would not stay down, and last and least willingly from the **Painted Mesa people**, who had said as much for longer than the mission had stood and had not been heeded. What lay under the water was no devil the padres had a rite to burn. It was a **Patron** (Player's Book Ch. VII) — one of the old reaching hands of the Dark — and it was coming up through the wells the way damp comes up through a wall.

They could not kill it. They did the next thing, and the harder one: they **bound** it. Blessed silver driven as nails — *clavos* — into the mouth of every spring and well in the basin; salt packed around each; a rite said over each; and the whole ring closed like a fence around the thing's reaching fingers. It held for a hundred years. The basin got its quiet century: cattle, three towns, a stage road, a county seat.

Now the seal is coming apart, and for three plain reasons — all of them the players' kind of trouble:

- **Drought.** The water table is dropping. Wells that were deep run shallow; nails driven into wet ground now sit in dust, and dry silver holds nothing.
- **Blasting.** The railroad is surveying the basin, and its powder has already split ground the padres sealed. (This is the crack in the *Salt Valley* seed of Ch. XI; Perdition Basin is that seed made a place.)
- **Greed.** The nails are silver, and silver is money to a ruined man. They are being pulled, one well at a time, by people who do not know or do not care what the nail was set to hold. The banker who dug up the wrong grave at Coffin Wells (Ch. IX) is only the first the players will meet.

Every nail that fails, a well goes bad, and something comes up through it. The basin does not fall all at once. It fails **well by well** — and that, drawn on a map, is your clock, your travelogue, and your whole campaign at once.

THE ONE THING TO HOLD

The players need to know none of this to begin. They ride into a town with a fever problem. The Truth is what *you* hold and they *earn*, in the order the map gives you: a bad well, then another, then the pattern, then the nails, then the mission, and only at the last the thing under the water. Name the whole shape late, or let them name it — and feel the floor go.

A Reckoning of the Wells

The binding is a ring of wells and springs, and the Keeper's map shows the state of each: a plain ring, the nail holds; a broken ring, the binding is failing; a struck-through ring, the well is gone and something is already loose. Restore the ring, or learn what it holds, before the last nail falls — that is the spine. Here is what each one is, and what it lets up when it goes.

The well	On the map	The truth beneath
Coffin Wells	broken	The first to fall. A Nightwalker (staked here by the padres) was dug up for its rumored silver; the dead now rise as Risen . This is <i>The Salt at Coffin Wells</i> — site ①, Ch. IX.
Saltlick well	failing	The seal thins, and the thinning drew a Skin-Walker to easy prey at the lonely relay. This is <i>A Face Not His Own</i> — site ②, Ch. X.
the Mission spring	failing	The heart of the ring, at San Clavo itself. When this nail goes, the Patron's hand is free. The whole campaign is the race to keep it, or re-drive it.
the South well	broken	Gone quietly, out in the Badlands, and nobody living near to notice yet. What came up is yours to choose (roll the Old Dark, Bestiary Ch. VII) — a whole reckoning waiting to be found.
Crossing well	bound	Still holds — it waters the county seat, so its nail is watched. If it ever fails, the disaster is <i>public</i> , and that is a reckoning of a different kind.
the North seep · Roadman's well · Painted spring	bound	The ring's still-sound quarter. The Painted spring the Mesa people tend themselves, and have far longer than the padres — ask why, and who taught whom.

The Places

Six places carry the county. Each is a scene waiting; each has a hook that pulls toward the ring. For a town you need on the fly, roll one up (Ch. XII) and hang it on the nearest well.

Calvary Crossing — the county seat

The one place in the basin with a marshal, a bank, a doctor, and a second street. It sits where the Stage Road fords the Calvary, and it is the closest thing to safe: its well still holds. Calvary Crossing is where the players resupply, hear the county's talk, and meet the men who are quietly pulling the nails and calling it progress. The bank is here, and so is the railroad's survey office. Play it as the ordinary west at its most convincing — so the floor has somewhere to drop.

Hook — the marshal, **T. Coyle** (Ch. II's voice), knows three wells have "gone sour" and is one honest man short of admitting it is more than water. He will not deputize strangers — until he has to.

Coffin Wells — the dying cattle town

A day south and west, a shrinking cattle town named for the boot-hill and the wells both. Its nail is *pulled* and its well is *broken*: this is where the campaign's dread first shows its face, and it is a finished night ready to run (Ch. IX). Run it first. Whatever the players do to the Nightwalker under the mission ground, the well stays broken unless a nail is re-driven — and re-driving a nail is a rite nobody left in Coffin Wells knows.

Hook — the banker **Josiah Vane**, if he lives through Ch. IX, is the thread straight to the faction pulling nails county-wide. If he dies, his ledger survives, and the ledger names names.

Saltlick Station — the lonely relay

A hard day north and east of the Crossing, the last roof for twenty miles on the Stage Road, out where the country gets thin. Its well is *failing*, and the failing drew the thing that now wears the hostler's face (Ch. X). Run it as the campaign's second night, or as the players' introduction to the idea that a bad well pulls predators the way a wound pulls flies.

Hook — whatever rides out of Saltlick at dawn wearing a new face (Ch. X) can ride straight into the next town on your map — a recurring hand for the whole year, if you let it live.

Mission San Clavo — the ruined heart

The oldest thing the settlers built, and a ruin for fifty years: a broken adobe church on the ground the padres chose because it sat over the Patron's reaching hand. The **Mission spring** rises in its cracked baptistry, and the master nail — the one that closes the whole ring — is driven into the altar stone. Come here and the campaign's true shape is on the walls: the padres' carvings, the record of the binding, and the warning they left for whoever came after. It is also where the last keeper of the ring can be found.

The Homesteads — where it shows first

Scattered between the towns, the outlying homesteads are the county's nerve endings. A well goes bad out here weeks before a town notices: the stock sicken, a buried kinsman comes home wrong, a family stops answering. The homesteads are your early-warning system and your bank of small, sharp tragedies — the Pell place (Ch. IX) is one; you have a dozen more in a single roll (Ch. XII).

The Painted Mesa — the ones who knew

Rising red in the south-east, the Painted Mesa is the ground of the people who were in this country long before the mission, and who told the padres what lay under the water — and were displaced for their trouble. They tend the Painted spring by rites older than the nails,

and they know things about the thing beneath that no carving at San Clavo records. They are not an oracle the players may squeeze. They are people with their own stake (the Patron threatens their ground too), their own grievance (the settlers owe them, not the other way around), and every right to weigh whether these particular strangers deserve help.

PLAY THEM AS PEOPLE

Give the Painted Mesa folk names, faces, disagreements, and interests of their own — an elder who counsels caution, a young rider who is done being patient with settlers, a keeper of the spring who will talk only once respect is earned in the fiction, not bought with a good roll. Their knowledge is a relationship, not a treasure. Handle the history plainly and without romance; the horror of Blood & Grit is the country's, and this is the part of it the settlers made themselves.

The Three Hands

Three interests pull on the basin. Each wants something the players can help or hinder; each is on the map as a wash of colour (see the Keeper's map). Run them as factions (Ch. VIII): know the want, and you can play the county.

- **The Vane Interest — the cattle-and-rail money.** Ruined ranchers, a hungry bank, and the railroad's agents, bound together by the one thing all of them want: the basin cheap and under their thumb. They are the hand pulling the nails — some for the silver, some to clear title to "sour" land, most too willful to hear what a nail was for. The human engine of the whole disaster, and the faction the players can actually punch.
- **The Last Bell of San Clavo — the ring's lone keeper.** One old soul who knows the truth of the nails and has been re-driving them alone for years, and is losing: **Padre Ildefonso**, or the layfamily that kept the mission after the church forgot it. Undermanned, half-broken, and the players' one source for the rite that closes a well. A quest-giver who is also a warning of where this ends.

- **The Painted Mesa people — the ones who knew.** Not a monolith and not a resource: a people with the oldest true knowledge of the thing under the water, their own reasons to want it kept down, and no debt to the settlers that would oblige them to fix the settlers' mess. Earn them, and they are the deepest well of truth in the basin. Fail them, and they will let the county reap what it planted — and who could blame them.

Running the Basin

You can run Perdition Basin three ways, and the map serves all three:

- **As a one-shot.** Run either reckoning (Ch. IX or X) exactly as written. The county is the world it happens in; the players need never see the ring.
- **As a short arc.** Run both reckonings back to back, then reveal the pattern — two bad wells, the same silver missing from each — and let the players decide to chase it. Three to five nights.
- **As the Haunted Year** (Ch. XI). The ring is the season clock. Each season a nail falls (you choose or roll which well); the players race the map, re-driving what they can and reckoning with what they can't, toward the Mission spring and the master nail. **The door that closes it:** re-drive the master nail at San Clavo — which costs a life freely given, the padres' price and now the players' — or find the older working the Mesa people hold, and pay *its* price instead. Either way, someone does not ride out of the basin.

For everything the map does not name — a town's third street, a homesteader's face, the rumor in the Crossing saloon — roll it live (Ch. XII) and hang it on the nearest well. The basin is built to be filled in at the table, not memorized before it.

THE MAP IS THE CAMPAIGN

Put the Keeper's map where you can see it and the players cannot. Every session, ask one question of it: *which nail is going next, and who is pulling it?* Answer that, and the country writes your next night for you — because a failing well is a place, a victim, a culprit, and a monster, all in one mark on a map. That is the whole trick of a Haunted County, and Perdition Basin is it, drawn out so you can see how.

XIV. The Lamplit City

Dodge, Kansas City, Frisco, Butte — and what the dark does with a crowd.



Out on the Cimarron a man screams and nobody hears him. In Kansas City a man screams and forty people hear him, and they go on in to supper. I have come to think the second is the worse country.

— PINKERTON OPERATIVE, REPORTING TO THE CHICAGO OFFICE



There is a fear, when a Keeper first moves the game off the open range, that the dark will not survive the gaslight — that a country horror needs a lonely country, and that a city with police in it, and a hospital, and four newspapers, and sixty thousand souls, is simply too well lit to be frightened in. Put the fear down. The dark does not need the dark. It needs to be able to work unremarked, and there has never been a better place for that than a city where nobody knows their neighbor's name.

By 1885 the West has cities, and they are not a compromise with the western — they are the western's other half. Dodge is the cattle capital of the continent. Kansas City runs the beef trade of a nation out of the West Bottoms. San Francisco is the great city of the West and about the ninth in the nation. Butte sits on the richest hill on earth and is hollow underneath. Every trail your players ride ends in one of these places, because that is where the money is, and the money is why anybody came. This chapter is how to run a night there without losing a thing.

Why the Dark Prefers a City

The country horror runs on isolation: nobody is coming, and the nearest help is a day's ride. A city takes that away and hands you something better in exchange.

- **Anonymity beats isolation.** A thing that takes one soul a week from a town of two hundred empties it in a season and is noticed by Tuesday. The same thing in Kansas City takes one a week forever. The population turns over constantly — drovers, rail hands, immigrants, whores, drifters, men whose families think they are in Oregon — and a missing stranger is not a mystery. It is a filing, if that.
- **The crowd is cover.** Out on the flat, a stranger on the ridge is an event. On Front Street a stranger is Tuesday. Things that could never cross open ground in daylight walk the city at noon in a good coat, and the only person who notices is the one who has learned what to look for — which is your party, and nobody else.
- **Indifference does the work fear used to.** The country horror's line is *nobody can hear you*. The city horror's line is *everybody heard you and went in to supper*. That is a colder note, and it plays.
- **Scale.** A haunting in the country takes a house. In a city it takes a block, a trade, a ward. A thing under Perdition Basin wants a valley. A thing under the Kansas City stockyards has its hand on the beef of a continent, and every steer the players ever drove came here to die.

What Changes at the Table

Six things, and only six. Everything else in this book runs unaltered.

1. The gun goes in a rack

Dodge City has a **deadline** — the railroad tracks — and north of it firearms are checked at the first place of business you enter, by ordinary municipal ordinance and a marshal with a shotgun. Most cattle towns have the same rule, and every real city has some version. This is the single best gift the setting ever gave a horror Keeper: it disarms the party *lawfully*, in a way they agreed to, in a place they chose to be. Make the check-in a scene. Then put the thing they need to shoot on the wrong side of the deadline at eleven at night.

2. Firing costs something

On the trail, a gunfight is a scene. In a city it is an arrest, a coroner's inquest, two newspapers, a bail bond, and a lawyer. Do not forbid it — charge for it. A justified killing still costs the party three days and a hundred dollars, and the thing they were chasing does not wait three days.

3. Witnesses and the press

Everything the players do in public happens in front of forty people and is in a newspaper by morning, usually wrong. This cuts both ways and both ways are good: they cannot quietly bury a problem, and they can, if they are clever, put a thing in the paper that its owner very badly needed kept out.

4. Help exists, and is worse

There are police, hospitals, and a coroner. Use them — and let the party learn that a city's institutions are not built to believe them. A man raving about the dead walking is not ignored in Kansas City; he is *committed* — a far more frightening end than being disbelieved on the trail. The asylum is the city's version of dying alone in the snow.

5. Paper is the new tracking

The country skills do not work here, so give the city its own: the newspaper morgue, the city directory, the county recorder, the coroner's inquest book, the hospital register, the ship manifest, the telegraph clerk who can be bought for two dollars. A party that learns to hunt through paper in a city is doing exactly what a party that learns to cut

The Bestiary, Downtown

Each kind bends differently to a city, and the bend is usually an improvement.

- **The Restless Dead (Ch. II).** The country's dead haunt a grave; a city's dead haunt a *system*. A potter's field with eleven thousand in it. A cholera trench built over by a good address. The dissection room at the medical college, and the resurrection men who supply it — the Resurrectionist stops being a lone ghoul with a spade and becomes a going concern with a price list and a standing order from a professor. Run a siege on a tenement block instead of a farmhouse and the numbers get worse in every direction.
- **Cursed Beasts (Ch. III).** Harder to hide and therefore better: a thing that must feed nightly in a city is on borrowed time, and knows it, and gets desperate on a clock. Put it in the stockyards, where a hundred thousand head a day are killed anyway and nobody counts a carcass twice. Or in the rail yards. Or the sewers, where the city puts everything it would rather not look at.
- **Men, and the Shapes of Men (Ch. IV).** The city is their native ground. A Skin-Walker in a town of two hundred is caught in a week because everyone knows everyone; in San Francisco it can wear a new face every month for a decade. The Mesmerist gets a lecture hall and a subscription list. The Deathless Gun gets a reputation, a saloon named after him, and an entire ward that would rather not testify.
- **Spirits & Hauntings (Ch. V).** Cities are built on their own dead ground, and the good ones are built on it twice. San Francisco's financial district stands on the hulls of the gold-rush fleet, scuttled and buried where they lay, and there are ships under those foundations with cargo and crew still in them. That is not an invention; it is the ground, and there is no finer haunting site in the West.

- **The Wild & the Weather (Ch. VI).** The one kind that weakens — so change its target. The Thirst in a city is the water main and the typhoid ward. The Red Wind is the smelter smoke that turns Butte's noon into night for three days at a stretch. A blizzard that kills one drover on the flat kills four hundred in a tenement district with no coal.
- **The Old Dark (Ch. VII).** Unchanged, and worse. What the Old Dark wants is scale, and a city is scale: a mine that goes down two thousand feet under a hundred thousand people, a subterranean waterworks, a ward it can hollow out one household at a time. Where the country gave it a valley, the city gives it an *industry*.
- **Hard Men & Hard Country (Bestiary Ch. IX).** Every entry survives the move and several improve. The Lynch Mob becomes a race riot with a fire company in it. The Hired Gun becomes a detective agency with a contract and an office. The Cattle Baron's Men become a corporation. Run these for the first month here exactly as you would on the range.

The Dark Cultist, Incorporated

This is the chapter's most useful idea, so take it whole. In the country a cult is a barn, a pit, and eleven people who have to meet in secret. In a city it does not have to hide at all — it **charters**.

It becomes the Benevolent Association, the Subscription Library, the Improvement Society, the Widows' and Orphans' Fund, the private lodge with a fine building on a good street and a brass plate by the door. It has a president, a treasurer, minute-books, and a lawyer. It gives generously and publicly. Its members are the alderman, the coroner, the editor of the second-largest paper, two police captains, and the man who holds the note on the boarding house where the party is staying. It does not need to silence a witness; it can simply outspend one, or sue one, or have one committed.

KEEPER'S EYE

The horror of this is not the robes. It is the moment the party realizes that every institution they were going to appeal to is already on the membership roll — and that the thing has been perfectly, boringly legal the entire time. Give the party one honest official, well down the ladder, with no power and a family. Everything the campaign is about will run through that person.

Practically: build the cult as a *faction* out of Chapter VIII, with a want, a lever, and a line. Its lever is money and standing. Its line is publicity — it will do a great deal, but not in front of the papers. Everything the party has to work with lives in that gap. The final scene of a city campaign is more often an exposure than a gunfight, and it should be: make the players choose between killing the thing and proving it, and let proving it be harder, slower, and better.

Ten Cities, Keyed

A hook apiece. Each is a real place in 1885, and the wrongness listed is yours to keep or trade.

Dodge City, Kansas cattle capital, ~1,200	The deadline at the tracks, Front Street, Boot Hill, and the Kansas quarantine law that is killing the trade this very year. A town with one boom left in it, and something under Boot Hill that has noticed the drives are ending.
Kansas City, Missouri ~100,000 and doubling	The West Bottoms: stockyards and packing houses where the whole beef of the continent comes to die, working day and night. Blood in the river. Something in the killing floors that has been very well fed for eleven years and has grown accordingly.
San Francisco, California ~250,000	Fog, the Barbary Coast, Chinatown, and a financial district built on the buried hulls of the abandoned gold fleet. Ships under the streets, with their holds shut. The city's foundations are a graveyard nobody consecrated.

Butte, Montana ~8,000 and climbing fast	The richest hill on earth, and entirely hollow — three thousand feet of workings under the houses, and men dying of the heat at depth. The smelter smoke blots out noon. Everything in this book that lives underground lives here.
Tombstone, Arizona ~5,000, falling	The silver is playing out and the lower workings are filling with water. A town on the way down is a town that will agree to anything, and what came up with the water table has opinions about who stays.
Omaha, Nebraska ~40,000, about to treble	Union Pacific headquarters, the shops, and the brand-new stockyards at South Omaha. Every soul heading west passes through, which means every soul heading west can be counted, followed, and selected from.
Denver, Colorado ~50,000	Larimer Street, the smelters, and new money building mansions on Capitol Hill fast enough to bury what the digging turned up. The respectable half of town is six years old and already has a secret.
Virginia City, Nevada the Comstock, past its peak	The deepest hard-rock workings on the continent, hot enough at the bottom to kill a man in an hour, and the Sutro Tunnel draining it. The mine is played out. Something is still down there, and the pumps are what is holding it.
Cheyenne, Wyoming ~6,000, and the richest club in the West	The Cheyenne Club, where the cattle barons take their brandy and decide who gets invaded. This is where the Regulators (Bestiary Ch. IX) are hired, over dinner, by men in evening dress.
Leadville, Colorado ~14,000 at 10,200 feet	A silver camp grown into a city where the air is thin, the winter is nine months, and the graveyard fills faster than the churches. Altitude, cold, and a boom that is one bad assay from over.

Building Your Own City

Chapter VIII builds a town with a want, a tell, and a secret. A city needs four more things, and they are the four that generate every plot you will ever need there.

- **An industry.** Cattle, silver, copper, rail, shipping, packing. It decides who lives there, what the air smells like, who has money, and what the city will forgive.
- **A machine.** Whoever really runs it — the ward boss, the association, the company, the committee of vigilance that never quite disbanded. The mayor is rarely the answer.
- **A quarter the city pretends not to have.** The tenderloin, the crib alley, the Chinese quarter, the shanties by the yards. This is where the dark works, because it is where the city has already agreed not to look.
- **A below.** Sewers, mine workings, cellars, a buried creek, a filled-in ravine, the old fort's magazine, the ships under the fill. Every city has one. The third act happens there.

d12 — A City's Wrong Note

1 the potter's field is full again · 2 the same charity buries them all · 3 a ward with no children in it · 4 the paper killed the story · 5 four inquests, one verdict · 6 the night shift will not go below · 7 a fine new building on bad ground · 8 the asylum is taking in strangers · 9 the police do not patrol one street · 10 the tunnels were bricked last spring · 11 a society nobody can join · 12 the mortality figures were amended

d10 — Who Runs This Town, Really

1 the packing company · 2 the ward boss and his saloon · 3 the mine's parent

corporation · 4 the vigilance committee that never disbanded · 5 the railroad's land office · 6 the bishop · 7 the newspaper · 8 the madam who holds everyone's secrets · 9 a benevolent association with a fine brass plate · 10 nobody, and that is the emergency

d10 — A City Job for a Country Posse

1 escort a witness to the courthouse · 2 find a drover's brother, last seen in the yards · 3 recover a body before the college does · 4 sit up with a coffin · 5 collect on a note nobody will collect on · 6 guard a payroll through the tenderloin · 7 find who is buying the fresh graves · 8 walk a reporter into the quarter and back · 9 identify the thing in the

charity ward · 10 attend a lodge dinner and
listen

KEEPER'S EYE — KEEPING THE TONE

The failure mode is letting the city become a different game: a mystery in overcoats, all parlors and no dust. Guard against it three ways. Keep the party's country competence *valuable* — they read sign, sit a horse, and stay calm with a gun, and the city has almost nobody who can do all three. Keep the money problems mundane: a hotel bill, a stabling fee, a fine. And get them out of town regularly — the best city campaigns run a ride out to a ranch, a mine, or a rail camp every third night, so the city is a place they come back to rather than a box they are stuck in. The West is the trail *and* the terminus. Run both, and the dark has twice as many doors.

Appendix: The Keeper's Screen

Every number you reach for, on one spread.



Everything a Keeper needs mid-night fits on one card. Everything a Keeper fears fits in the pause before the players roll.

— FROM A KEEPER'S LEDGER



The DC Ladder

Trivial 10 · Easy 13 · Average 15 · Hard 18 ·
Very Hard 20 · Punishing 25 · Beyond 30.
Against a living thing, use its Defense or
save instead.

The Four Degrees

Beat the DC by 10 (or nat 20) = critical
success. Miss by 10 (or nat 1) = critical
failure. Nat 20 / nat 1 shift one step.

Narrate all four.

Nerve & Breaking

Max Nerve = RES score + level; full each
session. At 0: roll the Break, take an

Dread Checks (Will save)

Corpse, murdered — DC 10, lose 1.

Mutilation — DC 13, lose 1d4.

Walking dead, true haunting — DC 16, lose
1d6.

The deep dark — DC 20, lose 1d10.

A world-unmaking truth — DC 25, 1d10 +
Affliction.

Crit success: no loss, steeled. Crit fail: lose +
Frightened 1.

Affliction, stay dangerous in play. Recover
only in true safety (1d4), never near the
dark.

The Mark (6 steps)

Grant for: breaking utterly (the rare roll), reaching for the Old Dark, surviving the deep dark changed. Never for a bad roll. At 6, the dark owns them.

Tainted Ground

Save every 3 days (Fort, then Will). Soured DC 13 · Blighted DC 16 · Unhallowed DC

Threat by Tier

I: Def 13 / Atk +4 / Blood 12.

II: 15 / +6 / 22.

III: 17 / +9 / 40.

IV: 20 / +13 / 70.

V: 23 / +17 / 110.

Fair fight $\approx$ party level = twice the Tier.

Budget 4 points/PC; even foe 4, mook 1, standout 8.

d12 — An Omen of the Dark

1 birds gone silent · 2 a cold that lamps won't touch · 3 milk soured, water iron · 4 a

20. Fail = +1 step (crit = +2). Wards & salt ease by 2.

Grit

3 per character per session; award more for courage, character, or a line that stops the table. Spent to add 1d6, reroll, steady a fright, stay on your feet at 0 Blood, or soften a critical failure.

dog that won't stop watching one door · 5 a shadow a beat behind its man · 6 a child's rhyme no one taught · 7 cattle dead untouched · 8 a grave clean and open · 9 the wrong number at the supper table · 10 a reflection that lags · 11 salt that won't pour · 12 your own name, called from the dark.

d10 — A Frontier Complication

1 the powder's wet · 2 a horse goes lame · 3 a stranger's already here · 4 the law wants a word · 5 a storm rolls in · 6 someone's been followed · 7 the bridge is out · 8 a debt comes due · 9 the wrong man overheard · 10 it's already too late for one of them.

d20 — A Name for Anyone

1 Amos · 2 Cassius · 3 Eb · 4 Halloran · 5 Jensen · 6 Coyle · 7 Ashby · 8 Vane · 9 Tuttle · 10 Pell · 11 Devereaux · 12 Calla · 13 Stroud · 14 Mercy · 15 Obadiah · 16 Sull · 17 Wren · 18 Hettie · 19 Lafe · 20 the one they will not name

d20 — A Name for the Rest of the County

Roll here as often as above — oftener, in the border counties and the rail towns (Ch. VIII).

1 Esperanza Ochoa · 2 Jubal Deets · 3 Wong Kai-lun · 4 Refugio Baca · 5 Delphia Kearse · 6 Ah Sing · 7 Trinidad Mestas · 8 Isham Boyd · 9 Soledad Herrera · 10 Lum Fong · 11 Prospero Vigil · 12 Naomi Pettiford · 13 Chee Yee · 14 Casimiro Luján · 15 Hosea Tolliver · 16 Altagracia Sandoval · 17 Willa Redd · 18 Yuen Sook-ping · 19 Eleuterio Padilla · 20 the one who has not given it yet

d12 — A Name Out of the Nations

Ask whose country you are in before you roll — these are seven unrelated peoples, not

one.

1 Quanah Parker's cousin, Comanche · 2 Ha-o-zinne, Chiricahua · 3 Little Elk, Kiowa · 4 Hastiin Tso, Diné · 5 Mary Sits-Alone, Crow · 6 Standing Bear's nephew, Ponca · 7 Yellow Robe, Lakota · 8 Josefa Antone, Tohono O'odham · 9 Two Kettles, Cheyenne · 10 Isidro Naranjo, of Taos · 11 Wetatonmi's daughter, Nez Perce · 12 a scout, and he has an Army name and a real one

d12 — A Town's Wrong Note

1 no children seen · 2 the church is locked · 3 too many fresh graves · 4 all owe the same man · 5 a bell rung nightly · 6 the well's gone bad · 7 a stranger they all defer to · 8 no dogs anywhere · 9 a name no one will say · 10 the doctor left sudden · 11 salt over every door · 12 they were expecting you

d10 — Why They're Out Here

1 a job gone quiet · 2 a name on a dodger · 3 kin stopped writing · 4 driving stock through · 5 running from the last town · 6 a map off a dying man · 7 the railroad sent them · 8 a debt to collect · 9 a grave to find · 10 nowhere left to be

d8 — What the Locals Whisper

1 it only takes the wicked (*false*) · 2 the old
church ground is salted for a reason · 3
don't drink from the east well · 4 the banker

knows more than he says (*true*) · 5 a child
saw it and won't speak · 6 it can't cross
running water · 7 the last lawman rode out
and never came back · 8 there's a way to end
it, but it costs



Blood & Grit · The Keeper's Book · Run it slow. Bleed the Nerve slower. Salt the grave.

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The craft, the country, and where each waits.

A leading “the” is ignored in the ordering. Where a concept fills a whole chapter, the page given is where that chapter opens.

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